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Hands that build, now backed



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Bengal polls: EC dismisses scope for wrongdoing at strongrooms



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Nothing changed us: Yami Gautam



TRUMP SAYS HE'S 'NOT SATISFIED' WITH PROPOSAL

Iran submits new proposal to end war

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

WASHINGTON: Iran has put forward a fresh proposal to the United States aimed at ending the two-month conflict, even as tensions continue to disrupt oil flows through the Strait of Hormuz and global markets remain on edge. The offer comes at a time when Washington maintains pressure on Tehran through sanctions and a naval blockade, while negotiations between the two sides continue through indirect channels.

Details of Iran's latest proposal have not been made public. However, earlier positions from Tehran indicated a willingness to reopen the strategically vital Strait of Hormuz and move toward a ceasefire, while seeking to delay discussions related to its nuclear programme. That sequencing was rejected by US officials, who insisted that nuclear restrictions must remain central to any agreement.

US President Donald Trump confirmed on Friday that he was unconvinced by the new offer. "They want to make a deal, I'm not satisfied with it, so we'll see what happens," he told reporters at the White House, without specifying the gaps in the proposal. He added that talks have continued



FILE PHOTO

over the phone after cancelling a planned envoy visit to Pakistan, describing Iran's leadership as "very disjointed" and internally divided over how to proceed.

According to a report by Axios, one of Washington's key demands is that Iran must not attempt to move enriched uranium from its damaged nuclear facilities or restart operations at those sites while negotiations are ongoing. The US has also maintained that Tehran should never be allowed to develop nuclear weapons, a position reiterated by White House

spokesperson Anna Kelly, who said negotiations were focused on both immediate and long-term security concerns.

The conflict, which began on February 28 amid a broader US-Israel military campaign targeting Iran, has had major economic and geopolitical consequences. Iran moved to effectively shut the Strait of Hormuz shortly after hostilities began, cutting off a crucial artery for global petroleum shipments. Although a ceasefire was announced on April 8, US forces have continued to restrict shipping linked to Iran

in the region.

The disruption has driven sharp volatility in oil markets. The Strait of Hormuz, through which a significant share of the world's oil supply passes, remains a focal point of concern for energy markets.

US Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent said the economic pressure campaign known as "Economic Fury" has pushed Iran's economy into severe distress. He stated that the country's currency has reached record lows, while shortages of US dollars have compounded financial strain. Bessent also claimed

that food and fuel rationing are currently in place.

"The blockade will continue until there is pre-February 27 freedom of navigation," Bessent said, adding that the United States maintains full control over the Strait. He also said Iran's oil sector was effectively paralysed and argued that the situation reflected growing international isolation of Tehran.

Despite these pressures, diplomatic channels remain open, with both sides continuing to explore options for a negotiated settlement.

HIGHLIGHTS

- » The Strait of Hormuz remains disrupted, affecting global oil shipments and market stability
- » Negotiations are continuing through phone discussions after a planned envoy trip to Pakistan was cancelled
- » The US insists Iran must not move enriched uranium or restart nuclear activity during ongoing talks
- » US Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent said Iran's economy is under severe strain, citing currency collapse and shortages
- » The US blockade of Iranian linked shipping in the Strait of Hormuz remains in place despite an April 8 ceasefire

WEST BENGAL ELECTIONS

SC to hear today TMC's plea against use of only central staff for counting

Party raises concerns over neutrality of staff

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court will take up on Saturday a petition filed by the Trinamool Congress challenging a Calcutta High Court ruling that upheld the Election Commission's decision to deploy central government and public sector undertaking employees for counting votes in the West Bengal Assembly election.

Polling for the 294-member Assembly was held in two phases on April 23 and April 29, with the counting of votes scheduled for May 4.

The high court dismissed the TMC's petition on Thursday, saying there was no illegality in the poll panel's decision to appoint counting supervisors and assistants from central government and public sector undertaking (PSU) employees instead of the state government staff.

According to the apex court's cause list for May 2, the TMC's plea will be heard by a bench of Justices P S Narasimha and Joydalya Bagchi.

In the high court, the TMC had challenged an April 30 communication issued by the

TAKEAWAYS

- » Case relates to EC directive on deploying central government and PSU staff for counting
- » Voting for 294-seat Bengal Assembly held on April 23 and April 29

- » Counting of votes scheduled for May 4
- » High Court found no illegality in EC's decision on counting personnel
- » TMC argued directive lacked jurisdiction and was based on "mere apprehension"

Repolling at 15 booths in 2 West Bengal constituencies today

MPOST BUREAU

KOLKATA: The Election Commission of India on Friday directed fresh voting in 15 polling stations across two Assembly segments in South 24 Parganas district of West Bengal, citing reports of irregularities during polling.

According to the order, repolling will take place on May 2 between 7 am and 6 pm. The affected booths include 11 in Magrahat Paschim and four in Diamond Harbour constituencies. Voting in both seats had earlier been conducted during the second phase of the state election on April 29.

The Commission said the decision followed inputs from returning officers, field observers and

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additional chief electoral officer of West Bengal that stated that at least one of the counting supervisors or assistants at

each table should be a central government or PSU employee. The TMC's counsel had argued

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SC grants anticipatory bail to Khara, flags 'unparliamentary' remarks by Assam CM Sarma

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court has granted anticipatory bail to Congress leader Pawan Khara in a criminal case linked to allegations he made against the wife of Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma, with the court noting that the dispute appears to stem from political rivalry and public exchanges during an election period.

A bench comprising Justices JK Maheshwari and AS Chandurkar, in an order uploaded on Friday, allowed Khara's plea for pre-arrest bail, subject to conditions, after reserving its verdict a day earlier.

The ruling set aside an April 24 order of the Gauhati High Court, which the apex court found to be based on an incorrect appreciation of material on record and said had erroneously shifted the burden onto the accused.

The case arises from a press conference held by Khara on April 6, 2026, ahead of the Assam Assembly elections, in which he alleged that the chief minister's wife possessed multiple passports and undisclosed foreign assets. During the briefing, Khara displayed what he claimed were three passports, including two purportedly from Muslim-majority countries.

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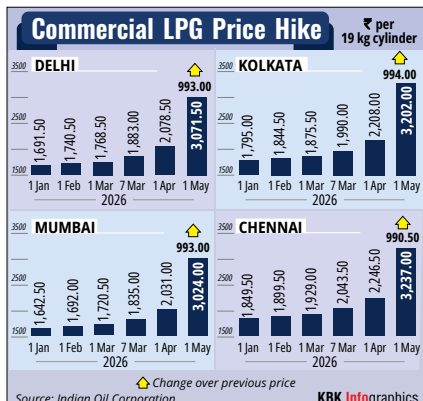
Prices of commercial LPG, 5-kg cylinders see steepest-ever hike

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Commercial LPG prices saw a record surge on Friday, with oil marketing companies raising rates by Rs 993 to Rs 3,071.50 per 19-kg cylinder, marking the steepest-ever increase and putting pressure on hotels, restaurants and other bulk users. The sharp hike comes amid a rise in global energy prices driven by supply disruptions linked to the ongoing conflict in West Asia.

Smaller 5-kg free trade LPG cylinders also recorded a significant jump, with prices climbing from Rs 549 to Rs 810.50 per bottle. The revised rate brings them close to the Rs 913 price of the 14.2-kg domestic LPG cylinder used in household kitchens, which remains unchanged.

The increase reflects the impact of global oil



prices, which have risen nearly 50 per cent in recent months. Supply constraints have worsened as the Strait of

Continued on P4

CALM CURRENTS



People kayaking in the Lower Lake amid overcast conditions, in Bhopal, Madhya Pradesh, Friday

PTI

Noida Int'l Airport to start commercial flights from June 15



FILE PHOTO

DIPIKA KIROLA

NOIDA: The much-awaited Noida International Airport is set to commence commercial flight operations from June 15, 2026, marking a major milestone in boosting air connectivity across the National Capital Region (NCR) and western Uttar Pradesh.

The announcement comes after the airport's inauguration by Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath, along with the receipt of approval for the Aerodrome Security Programme (ASP) from the Bureau of Civil Aviation Security (BCAS).

The clearance confirms that the airport's security systems and operational procedures meet all regulatory requirements ahead of the launch.

"IndiGo will operate the first flight from the airport, formally kickstarting scheduled passenger services. Other carriers, including Akasa Air and Air India Express, are expected to follow soon," said Chief Executive Officer (CEO) RK Singh.

Detailed flight schedules, destinations, and passenger services are likely to be announced in the coming days.

Strategically located in Jewar, the airport is being developed to cater to the rapidly growing demand for

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AAP govt wins confidence vote in Punjab Assembly, raises minimum wages by 15%

SWATI MAHAJAN

CHANDIGARH: The Aam Aadmi Party government in Punjab secured a vote of confidence in the state Assembly on Friday, with Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann stating that the result had ended speculation about instability within the ruling party. The motion, introduced during a special one-day session held on Labour Day, was passed unanimously in the absence of most opposition members, days after a setback in the Rajya Sabha where seven AAP MPs defected to the Bharatiya Janata Party.

Presenting the motion, Mann



rejected claims of internal divisions, saying rumours of MLAs switching sides were unfounded. "There are rumours that AAP will be finished and its MLAs would switch sides. Such rumours create an illusion in people's minds," he said in the House. After the vote, he said speculation about "65 or 40 MLAs" leaving the party had been put to rest.

The motion was adopted without opposition participation, as Congress staged a walkout and the BJP boycotted the proceedings. Members of the Shiromani Akali Dal and the Bahujan Samaj Party were also not present, leaving only an Independent MLA in the House when the motion was passed. The ruling party had issued a whip to ensure full attendance of its legislators.

In the 117-member Assembly, AAP holds 94 seats. The Congress has 16 MLAs, the Shiromani Akali Dal three, the BJP two, the BSP one, and there is one independent legislator.

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77% OF GOLD (680 MT) IS NOW STORED DOMESTICALLY

India shifts majority of gold reserves home amid geopolitical uncertainty

MPOST BUREAU

MUMBAI: The Reserve Bank of India has significantly increased the share of its gold reserves stored within the country, bringing back more than 100 metric tonnes in just six months, according to the latest data released by the Reserve Bank of India. The move reflects a broader global reassessment of where sovereign wealth is held, as geopolitical tensions and financial risks reshape how central banks manage their assets.

The Reserve Bank said it repatriated 104.23 metric tonnes of gold during the October 2025 to March 2026 period. India's total gold holdings rose marginally to 880.52 met-



ric tonnes by the end of March 2026, compared with 880.18 metric tonnes in September 2025. A much larger shift, however, was seen in the loca-

KEY POINTS

- » RBI repatriated 104.23 metric tonnes of gold between October 2025 and March 2026
- » India's total gold reserves rose slightly to 880.52 MT from 880.18 MT six months earlier
- » 197.67 MT remains with the Bank of England and Bank for International Settlements; 2.80 MT is held as deposits
- » Gold's share in forex reserves increased to 16.7% from 13.92%, aided by rising prices
- » India's total forex reserves stood near \$691.1 billion during the period
- » Of foreign currency assets (\$552.28 billion), \$465.61B was in securities, \$46.83B with central banks/BIS, \$39.84B with overseas commercial banks

tion of these reserves. Nearly 77 per cent of the gold is now stored domestically, amounting to roughly 680 metric tonnes, marking a sharp rise

from earlier years when a majority was kept overseas.

The central bank's half-yearly report showed

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Above-normal heatwave days likely in May: IMD

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: India is likely to face a mixed weather pattern in May, with higher-than-usual heatwave days forecast for several regions, even as overall rainfall is expected to exceed normal levels, according to the India Meteorological Department.

In its monthly outlook released on Friday, the IMD said parts of the Himalayan foothills, east coast states, Gujarat and Maharashtra could see an increase in heatwave conditions during the month. At the same time, rainfall across the country as a whole is projected to be above normal, though some areas in east, northeast and east-central India may receive



less rain than usual. Mrutyunjay Mohapatra said minimum temperatures are expected to remain elevated across large parts of the country in May 2026. "During May 2026, minimum temperatures are expected to be above normal across many parts of

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LOW-INCOME HOUSEHOLDS HIT HARDEST

Irregular supply leaves Capital’s water-stressed areas grappling

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: As temperatures soar across the capital, residents in water-stressed pockets such as Sangam Vihar and Tughlakabad say the ongoing alternate-day water supply is worsening the challenges of daily life, especially for low-income households.

In these densely populated areas, piped water is either supplied once every two days or, in some cases, even less frequently, leaving families struggling to cope with rising summer demand. Many households are forced to store water in limited containers or depend on expensive private tankers.

One resident from Sangam Vihar shared that water availability is highly irregular. “Water comes here once in 10 to 15 days sometimes. We have no option but to depend on private supply,” he said. “We even have to pay extra money along with rent to the landlord for a private water connection. There is no other way for us.”

Another resident, Rafiq, said, “When water comes after two days, it is not enough. We have a big family, and managing with stored water is very



difficult in this heat.”

In Tughlakabad, Sunita, a domestic worker, highlighted the financial burden. “Private tankers charge around Rs.500 for one hour. We cannot afford this regularly, but sometimes we have no choice. Water is more important than anything else,” she said.

Residents said the situation is particularly tough for labourers who spend long hours outside and return home to limited or no water supply. “After working all day in the heat, we don’t even have enough water to bathe or cook properly,” said Manoj, a construction worker.

Back in March, Delhi Jal Board had announced a summer action plan to tackle water shortages. Water Min-

ister Parvesh Verma had said the focus would be on sustaining production and improving accountability.

“Supplying clean water and protecting the Yamuna are not just administrative tasks but a shared responsibility,” he had said.

The plan includes maintaining a peak supply of around 1,002 MGD, preparing major treatment plants such as Chandrawal, Wazirabad, Okhla and Dwarka, expanding tube wells, and deploying around 1,200 GPS-enabled tankers to improve transparency.

Despite these measures, residents say last-mile delivery remains a challenge. “Every year we hear about plans, but

“DTC has also made arrangements to provide free drinking water in nearly 3,000 buses operating across the Capital”

on the ground, the problem continues,” another resident said. “Until water comes daily, summers will remain a struggle for us.”

DTC’s ‘Jaldoot’ initiative
In a bid to provide relief to commuters amid rising temperatures, the Delhi Transport Corporation (DTC) on Friday launched its ‘Jaldoot’ initiative, offering free drinking water at key locations across the city.

Under the initiative, ‘Jaldoots’ have been deployed at 23 major bus terminals to distribute free drinking water to passengers, particularly targeting daily commuters vulnerable to extreme heat conditions. The move comes as part of the broader heatwave action plan

being implemented under the directions of Chief Minister Rekha Gupta and Transport Minister Pankaj Kumar Singh. In addition to on-ground distribution points, DTC has also made arrangements to provide free drinking water in nearly 3,000 buses operating across Delhi, significantly expanding access to hydration during travel.

“Ensuring passenger welfare during extreme weather conditions is our top priority. Through the ‘Jaldoot’ initiative, we are making every effort to provide immediate relief and essential support to commuters across Delhi. I urge all citizens to stay hydrated and take necessary precautions during the heatwave,” Singh said.

Officials said the initiative builds on last year’s rollout, which had received a positive response from the public. This year, the programme has been expanded to increase its reach and impact.

DTC also advised commuters to avoid unnecessary exposure to direct sunlight during peak afternoon hours and to remain hydrated as temperatures continue to rise in the national capital.

Man stabbed near residence in Trilokpuri, accused on the run

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A man was allegedly stabbed by two persons known to him in east Delhi’s Trilokpuri area, police said on Friday.

Both accused have been identified and multiple teams have been formed to apprehend them, they said.

A PCR call regarding a stabbing incident was received around 10 pm on April 30, the police said, adding that the caller informed about an injured person with stab wounds admitted to a nearby hospital.

“A police team rushed to the hospital, where the victim was found undergoing treatment and later referred to AIIMS Trauma Centre for advanced care after initial examination,” an officer said.

Preliminary inquiry revealed that the victim was near his residence in Trilokpuri along with the person who had called the police, when the two accused arrived and allegedly attacked him with knives.

“The assailants fled the scene after the attack and the motive behind the incident is being ascertained,” the officer added.

Based on the complainant’s statement and medical evidence, a case has been registered under the relevant provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya

Soldier suffers facial injuries in bus stabbing; accused arrested

NEW DELHI: A man who allegedly attacked an Army personnel with a knife in a bus near Old Delhi Railway Station has been arrested, an official said on Friday.

The alleged attack by Ganesha, a vagabond currently living in the Chandni Chowk area and a native of Prahladpur in Delhi, left the soldier with grievous injuries on the face.

Some days later around 7 pm on April 25, two police officers on night patrol duty spotted a man behaving suspiciously in the Chandni Chowk area. On seeing the police, the suspect attempted to flee but police chased him and overpowered him after a brief pursuit.

During his search, a button-actuated knife was recovered from his possession. A case under relevant sections of the Arms Act was registered at Lahori Gate police station, and further investigation was initiated, police said.

During sustained interro-



gation, Ganesh allegedly confessed to his involvement in a recent assault case reported in the same police station area.

Upon verification, police linked him to a case registered on April 25 under Section 118(1) (voluntarily causing hurt or grievous hurt using dangerous weapons) of the BNS.

Police said the victim in the case is an Army personnel who had boarded a bus to Sarai Rohilla railway station to travel to Rajasthan. An altercation inside a bus near Old Delhi Railway Station led to a knife attack on an Army man, causing grievous facial injuries. The accused, later identified, is allegedly a drug addict.

MPOST

3 nabbed for assaulting lawyer in court premises granted relief by court

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A Delhi court has granted bail to three persons accused of assaulting an advocate inside the Karkardooma court complex in April, saying that the investigation was almost complete and no further custodial interrogation was required.

Additional Sessions Judge Surabhi Sharma Vats was hearing the bail applications filed by Uday Sethi, Rohan Kakkar and Rohit Sethi in connection with a case registered at the Farsh Bazar police station for allegedly assaulting the lawyer.

In an order dated April 28, the court said, “Investigation in the present matter qua the applicants/accused is stated to be almost complete. Custodial interrogation of the accused/applicants is stated to be not required. It is further stated that nothing is to be recovered from or at the instance of the applicants/accused.”

According to the prosecution, the three accused allegedly attacked advocate Aman inside the Karkardooma court premises on April 7, causing injuries to his head with a pointed object.

The court was informed that the accused and the com-

“Three accused allegedly attacked advocate Aman inside the Karkardooma court”

plaintain were known to each other and that the accused were clients of the injured lawyer.

The prosecution opposed the bail pleas, submitting that the allegations were serious in nature and that the complainant had suffered head injuries in the attack.

“The applicants/accused persons Uday Sethi and Rohan Kakkar are stated to be young boys aged about 21 years and 25 years respectively and are also stated to be students. It is reported by the IO - one case against the applicant/accused Uday Sethi is the POCSC case previously lodged by the complainant only,” the court said.

Defence claimed false implication, calling it a mutual scuffle, and cited CCTV. Police said the probe is nearly complete and the weapon recovered. Granting bail, the court noted custody since April 7 and set conditions on release.

DU reschedules PG examination

NEW DELHI: Delhi University (DU) has announced the rescheduling of some postgraduate and professional semester examinations due to unavoidable circumstances.

As per a DU notification dated April 29, “...due to unavoidable circumstances, no examination shall be held between May 20, 2026 and May 25, 2026. The competent authority has decided to reschedule the postgraduate and professional semester examinations originally scheduled to be held between May 20 and May 25.”

The notification, signed by the Controller of Examination, requested all departments to send revised date sheets for approval by the competent authority.

It mentioned that the revised date sheet should be communicated to all concerned faculty members and students. “It should be displayed on the departmental notice boards as well as uploaded on the official university website,” it said.

IGIA dog disappearance: Court flags lapses, seeks fresh inquiry

Joint CP (Transport) asked to conduct fresh inquiry

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A court here has asked the Joint Commissioner of Police for the Transport Range in Delhi to conduct a fresh probe into an IGI Airport dog missing case, terming the earlier police inquiry “inadequate” and lacking “serious efforts”.

Complainant and airport feeder Rashim Sharma said that the case pertains to two missing community dogs, “Kaddu and Brownie”, who have remained untraceable for over a month following their alleged illegal relocation from the airport’s terminal 1 and terminal 3.

“The court has taken cognisance and expressed serious concern,” she said.

Additional Chief Judicial Magistrate Pranav Joshi of Patiala House Courts observed on Wednesday that the police’s status reports were “inadequate” and reflected a lack of



“serious efforts” to ascertain key facts, including the dogs’ whereabouts and the role of those involved. The court noted that although CCTV footage showed a person luring a dog into a vehicle, no clear conclusions were drawn.

The court observed that the investigating officer failed to get to the root of the matter and instead focused on questioning the complainants rather than the alleged perpetrators.

Flagging gaps in the probe, the court said even basic details such as vaccination and ster-

Corporation is not planning to conduct any sealing drive in the city: Mayor

Mayor Pravesh Wahi after taking charge on Wednesday had announced that corporation is not planning to conduct any sealing drive in the city.

CTI Chairman Brijesh Goyal said traders conveyed that the upcoming Master Plan 2041 is expected to provide clarity on the demarcation of residential, commercial and industrial areas across Delhi.

“Till then, no survey or sealing action should be undertaken,” he said.

Representatives from key markets, including Karol



in the case had already been arrested earlier. The role of the constable surfaced during the

Bagh, Sadar Bazaar and Gandhi Nagar, told the commissioner that no area in Delhi is purely residential and pointed out that commercial activities are permitted in 24 categories even in residential zones, the statement read.

They stressed the need for clearer classification of land use to avoid confusion and hardship for traders.

Traders said that the commissioner responded to the concerns.

The MCD Commissioner said action will follow consultations with agencies, assuring traders against harassment, Goyal said. He added traders may soon get licences online by paying 15 per cent fee with property tax; an order is expected shortly.

Constable apprehended in ₹50L Azad Mkt robbery case

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A Delhi Police constable has been arrested for his alleged involvement in a Rs 50 lakh robbery near the Azad Market underpass last month, an official said on Friday.

The accused, identified as Samay Singh, was posted in the 5th Battalion of the Delhi Police.

He is alleged to have con-

spired with a group of associates to execute the robbery on March 31, they said.

According to police, the incident took place when four men intercepted a moving auto-rickshaw near the Azad Market underpass and decamped with cash worth around Rs 50 lakh. A case was registered, and an investigation was launched immediately.

“Several accused involved

course of the investigation,” a senior police officer said.

Singh had been absconding since the incident and was tracked down after sustained efforts by a police team using CCTV footage and technical surveillance, officials said.

He was eventually apprehended in Rajasthan’s Dausa. Police suspect that Singh played a key role in planning the robbery and coordinating

with his associates.

“He is considered a habitual offender who has been involved in major robbery cases,” the officer said.

Further investigation is underway to ascertain the full extent of his involvement and to verify whether he was linked to other similar crimes. Efforts are also being made to trace the remaining proceeds of the robbery, police said.

3 dead in truck-on-truck collision

OUR CORRESPONDENT

GURUGRAM: Three people were killed after a truck rammed into another on the IMT Manesar flyover on the Delhi-Jaipur highway in the early hours on Friday, police said.

A truck was parked on the side of the road without reflectors or indicators and a moving truck crashed into it. All three deceased were in the moving truck, they said.

An FIR was registered against the driver of the parked truck and police handed over the bodies to the kin after the postmortem.

The complaint was filed by the deceased truck driver’s brother Durga Prasad, a resident of Jaunpur, Uttar Pradesh.

The complainant said he

and his brother Shankar Bind, both truck drivers, were driving from Bhiwadi to Delhi on Thursday night. Shankar’s truck was in front, while he was behind. When the vehicles reached the flyover at IMT Manesar around 2 am, a vehicle ahead of Shankar’s truck suddenly changed lanes and his truck collided with the rear of a truck parked on the road.

A stationary truck without signals or reflectors allegedly caused a collision, leaving three men — Shankar Bind, Sunil Kumar and Ramraj Prasad — critically injured, a complaint said.

They were rushed to hospital but declared dead. Police said a probe is underway to determine why the truck was parked on the highway and to identify the driver.

Cops bust illegal drug network operating from chemist’s shop

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police have arrested a pharmacist for allegedly running an illicit drug racket under the guise of a medical store in west Delhi’s Nihal Vihar.

The accused, identified as Manoj Kumar alias Manish (31), a resident of Nihal Vihar, was apprehended following a tip-off received by the Anti Auto Theft Squad (AATS).

Acting on specific intelligence on April 28, police, in coordination with the Drugs Department, conducted a joint raid that exposed the illegal sale and distribution of restricted medicines to addicts.

During the operation, officials seized 50 bottles of codeine syrup, classified as a commercial quantity, along with 499 capsules and 400 tablets of Tramadol, also falling under commercial quantity. In addition, 240 capsules of Alprazolam, categorised as an intermediate quantity,



‘Kumar was using his chemist shop as a front to operate an illegal drug supply chain catering to substance abusers’

were recovered.

Investigators said the contraband was concealed inside a covered transparent plastic box within the shop to evade detection. Batch numbers and expiry dates on the medicines had allegedly been erased to obscure their origin and bypass

regulatory checks.

All recovered substances were sealed on the spot as per legal procedure.

A case has been registered at Nihal Vihar police station under relevant provisions of the Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances (NDPS) Act — including Sections 21(c), 22(b) and 22(c) — along with provisions of the Drugs and Cosmetics Act.

Police said Kumar was using his chemist shop as a front to operate an illegal drug supply chain catering primarily to substance abusers in the area. He has been taken into custody, and further investigation is underway to trace the source of the contraband and identify other members of the network.

The operation was carried out by an AATS team led by Inspector Vikram Sangwan under the supervision of ACP Virender Dalal, with assistance from SI Sandeep Sheoran, ASI Manjeet and other personnel.

‘MUST BECOME A COMMITMENT, NOT JUST A SLOGAN’

Catch the rain 2026: ‘Neera’ drives city’s mega water mission



AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: With a strong pitch to turn water conservation into a public movement, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Friday launched the ‘Catch the Rain 2026’ campaign, unveiling a water mascot ‘Neera’ and announcing incentives and mandates to boost rainwater harvesting across the Capital.

Addressing a Delhi Jal Board event, the Chief Minister stressed that the campaign must go beyond symbolism. “Catch the Rain must become a commitment, not just a slogan,” she said, adding, “Water is not just a resource, it is the foundation of life, the backbone of the economy, and a safeguard for future generations.”

The campaign aligns with the national call of “Catch the Rain, where it falls, when it falls,” articulated by Narendra Modi. Gupta highlighted the urgency of tackling water scarcity amid

“Water is not just a resource, it is the foundation of life, the backbone of the economy, and a safeguard for future generations” — CM REKHA

rising population and depleting groundwater levels, calling for immediate and collective action.

As part of the initiative, rainwater harvesting systems will be made mandatory for buildings measuring 100 square metres or more. To encourage adoption, the government will offer a rebate of up to 10 percent on water bills, along with financial assistance of up to Rs 50,000 and technical support through the Delhi Jal Board.

The Chief Minister also announced that all government offices will be required to install rainwater harvesting systems, with existing infrastructure to be repaired and brought under digital monitoring. She emphasised that maintenance is as important as installation to ensure effective groundwater recharge. Highlighting everyday solutions, Gupta urged citizens to adopt simple practices such as channeling rooftop rainwater, fixing leaks, and using water responsibly.

“Improving groundwater levels and securing water for future generations is a shared responsibility,” she said.

The event was attended by Water Minister Praveesh Sahib Singh, MP Bansuri Swaraj, and MLA Anil Kumar Sharma, among others. The government said the campaign will be a key step in addressing Delhi’s ongoing challenges of water scarcity and sustainability.

Speaker Gupta launches rainwater harvesting project

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Emphasising urgent action on urban water conservation, Delhi Assembly Speaker Vijender Gupta on Friday inaugurated a rainwater harvesting project in Rohtas Nagar, calling it a critical step towards securing the city’s water future.

Addressing the inaugural event at the Delhi Jal Board store near Loni Road, Gupta said, “A city that allows its rainwater to drain away cannot secure its future. Every drop must be captured, conserved and returned to the ground.”

The project was launched in the presence of Labour Minister Kapil Mishra and local

MLA Jitender Mahajan, and is aimed at improving groundwater recharge and promoting sustainable urban water management.

Highlighting the growing challenges of population pressure, rapid urbanisation and declining groundwater levels, Gupta said water conservation can no longer

remain optional for Delhi. He noted that rainwater, often wasted, can become a reliable resource if systematically harnessed.

Calling the initiative a model for replication, the Speaker praised local efforts and said such projects can significantly contribute to long-term environmental sus-

tainability and water resilience in the Capital. He also urged citizens to adopt rainwater harvesting practices at homes and institutions, stressing the need for collective responsibility.

“Inaction today will impose a serious cost on future generations,” he warned, appealing especially to the youth to lead awareness efforts.

Leprosy may soon be notifiable in Capital

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government is set to declare leprosy a notifiable disease under the Delhi Epidemic Diseases Act, a move aimed at strengthening surveillance, ensuring early detection and improving treatment compliance across the national capital, officials said on Friday.

The Delhi Health Department has cleared the proposal, and it is awaiting approval.

Once notified, hospitals, clinics and individual practitioners will be required to report cases to the District Leprosy Officer, enabling targeted interventions, timely diagnosis and free treatment through Multi-Drug Therapy at government facilities, an official statement said. The move will place Delhi among the states, such as Tamil Nadu, Maharashtra, Karnataka, Uttarakhand and West Bengal, that have made leprosy a notifiable disease.

Health Minister Dr Pan-kaj Kumar Singh said the step would help identify hidden cases, curb transmission and ensure that all patients receive standard treatment with dignity.

“Leprosy is completely curable. Making it a notifiable disease will help us find hidden cases, stop transmission and ensure every patient gets standard treatment with dignity,” he said.

The notification is expected to be issued following approval under the Government of National Capital Territory of Delhi Act, 1991, with detailed reporting guidelines to be

The move will place Delhi among the states, such as Tamil Nadu, Maharashtra, Karnataka, Uttarakhand and West Bengal, that have made leprosy a notifiable disease

shared soon with healthcare institutions across Delhi.

India officially achieved the elimination of leprosy as a public health problem in December 2005, meeting the WHO criteria of less than one case per 10,000 population at the national level. However, the country still accounts for nearly 59 per cent of global annual new cases, the official statement said.

Officials said a recent pan-India study found that around 44.1 per cent of leprosy patients are treated in private healthcare facilities and go unreported under the National Leprosy Eradication Programme, leading to continued transmission in the community.

They added that mandatory notification would help in early detection, reduce disability risk, enable contact tracing and post-exposure prophylaxis, improve treatment adherence and address stigma by recognising leprosy as a treatable disease.

The World Health Organisation has also recommended inclusion of leprosy in the list of notifiable diseases to strengthen monitoring and control efforts.

Temps dip below normal across Delhi

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A day after rain and hail lashed parts of the Capital, bringing respite from the intense heat, the city on Friday witnessed a departure from above-normal temperatures, with the maximum recorded at 36.4 degrees Celsius, 2.9 notches below normal.

The weather office has forecast a partly-cloudy sky, with possibility of thunderstorm and lightning later in the night.

According to the India Meteorological Department (IMD), the city’s base weather station at Safdarjung recorded 36.4 degrees Celsius as maximum temperature, while the minimum settled at 22.8 degrees Celsius, 1.9 notches below normal.

Station-wise data showed Palam recorded a maximum



of 35.1 degrees Celsius, five notches below normal, while Lodhi Road logged 34.6 degrees Celsius, 3.4 degrees below normal.

The Ridge station recorded a maximum temperature of 34.9 degrees Celsius, 5.1 notches below normal, while Ayanagar registered 35.4

degrees Celsius, 5.4 notches below normal.

Simultaneously, weather stations across Delhi recorded below-normal minimum temperatures too.

Palam recorded a minimum of 21.3 degrees Celsius, 4.3 notches below normal, while Lodhi Road logged 21.8

degrees Celsius, 1.2 notches below normal.

The Ridge recorded a minimum of 20.4 degrees Celsius, 4.6 notches below normal, while Ayanagar registered 21.4 degrees Celsius, 2.2 notches below normal.

Meanwhile, Delhi’s Air Quality Index (AQI) was recorded in the ‘moderate’ category at 119 in the evening.

According to the Central Pollution Control Board’s (CPCB) SAMEER app, 29 monitoring stations logged AQI readings in the ‘moderate’ category, 14 in the ‘satisfactory’ category, and one in the ‘very poor’ category.

As per CPCB norms, an AQI of 0 to 50 is considered ‘good’, 51 to 100 ‘satisfactory’, 101 to 200 ‘moderate’, 201 to 300 ‘poor’, 301 to 400 ‘very poor’, and 401 to 500 ‘severe’.

YOUR PARTICIPATION PLAYS AN IMPORTANT ROLE IN SHAPING THE FUTURE OF OUR CITY, NATION: L-G

Delhi launches online self-enumeration for Census

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Self-enumeration under Census 2027 began in the national capital on Friday, with many residents, including Lt Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu and Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, completing the exercise on day one.

The chief minister, after completing online self-enumeration, said the process is simple and completely safe.

She urged Delhi residents to take part in self-enumeration and pointed out that correct information and data pave the

way for correct policies to benefit every needy person.

Sandhu, in a post on X, said that the exercise officially began across all Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) wards and urged the residents to take part in the self-enumeration process and support the census.

“Your participation plays an important role in shaping the future of our city and nation,” he said in the post.

This digital-first initiative gives citizens the power to directly submit their household details, helping ensure every resident is accurately counted.



The CM, after completing online self-enumeration, said the process is simple and completely safe

Reliable data is key to inclusive governance and a stronger, developed nation, the L-G added. Self-enumeration exercise has already been completed in New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) and Delhi Cantt areas, where houselisting and housing operations through door-to-door visits by enumerators are underway. All residents of MCD wards, irrespective of their domicile status, can participate in the voluntary self-enumeration exercise by logging on to the Census portal, officials said. Only one login per household will be required, and the

head of the family or any other member can complete the process using a mobile number. Users will have to select a language at the time of first login, which cannot be changed later, they said. The process will also require respondents to provide the geo-coordinates of their residence, either by selecting the location on a satellite map, searching the address on the portal, or manually entering latitude and longitude, they said.

An 11-digit self-enumeration ID will be generated after submission of the details, which will be produced by the peo-

ple to the census enumerators who will visit households door to door for recording under Houselisting and Housing operations from May 16 to June 14.

A toll-free helpline (1855) has been provided for assistance related to the census exercise, officials said. There are 250 wards of the MCD in which self-enumeration will take place from May 1 to May 15. The self-enumeration portal is available in 16 languages, including Hindi, English, Bengali, Tamil and Urdu, and includes built-in FAQs, tooltips and validation checks to improve accuracy.

No PUC, no fuel: 15K+ vehicles turned away

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

NEW DELHI: In a renewed push to curb vehicular pollution in the national capital, the Delhi government has intensified enforcement of its “no PUC, no fuel” rule, leading to over 15,000 vehicles being turned away from fuel stations in just four days from April 26 to 29, as per data accessed by the PTI.

The move signals a stricter on-ground implementation of existing norms to tackle the city’s persistent air quality crisis.

This comes after the government, on April 22, reiterated that vehicles without a valid



Pollution Under Control (PUC) certificate will not be provided fuel in Delhi.

While the provision was introduced in October 2025, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta

had called for stricter implementation of the same in April this year. An official told PTI, “A significant number of vehicles without a valid PUC certificate are being denied fuel daily.

In just four days, for example, over 15,000 vehicles were turned down.” According to the data accessed by the PTI, 3,525 vehicles were denied fuel by fuelling stations on April 26 for not having a valid PUC; 4,012 vehicles were denied it on April 27; 4,235 vehicles on April 28 and 3,906 vehicles on April 29.

The total number of vehicles for the four days stood at 15,678, which corresponded to the number of vehicles found without a valid PUC at nine depots across Delhi and one in Noida.

“The numbers are in sync with the government’s attempts

for stricter implementation of the ‘no PUC, no fuel’ policy, so that effective control over vehicular pollution can be ensured,” the official said.

Under Rule 115 (sub-rule 7) of the Central Motor Vehicles Rules, 1989, every vehicle must carry a valid PUC certificate after one year of registration and produce it on demand.

However, in April this year, the government noted that despite implementation of the rule, a large number of vehicles continued to operate without valid certification, significantly aggravating pollution levels in the city.

Shanti Van-Rajghat set for MAKEOVER

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government has approved a beautification project for the Ring Road stretch between Shanti Van and Rajghat intersection, the Public Works Department (PWD) said on Friday.

Under the plan, the PWD will undertake a facelift of roads in the Rajghat area, focusing on improved illumination, installation of decorative street lights and horticulture work.

The initiative aims to enhance the aesthetic appeal of the area, which holds both national and international significance. Rajghat, the memorial of Mahatma Gandhi, is frequently visited by foreign dignitaries during official trips to India. It also attracts a large number of tourists and visitors on a daily basis.

“As part of the plan, the street light poles will be made of decorative mild steel work, with LED white light arrangements inside. These would be smart lights, there will also be repair work on the roads wherever required. Tenders have been floated in this regard,” a PWD official said.

The project has to be completed in two months time at the estimated cost of Rs 96 lakh.

This is the second project initiated by the government for the VIP area, this year.

Earlier this year, the PWD also planned a signal-free corridor between Shanti Van crossing and Rajghat crossing to reduce congestion in the area.

“The department is working on a trial infrastructure project aimed at making Ring Road signal-free through U-turns at the Rajghat and Shanti Van crossings,” official added.

Both the crossings witness heavy traffic throughout the day, often resulting in long queues and frequent slowdowns, especially during peak hours, officials added.

Traffic police officials had flagged delay at these junctions due to signalised intersections and turning movements that interrupt traffic flow.

The proposed infrastructure will focus on implementing a U-turn-based traffic management scheme which involves restricting certain right turns and streamlining vehicle movement through designated turning points.

According to officials, such interventions are aimed at reducing signal dependency, minimising crossing conflicts and improving average travel speed.

Hands that build, now backed

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Marking International Workers’ Day with a strong welfare push, Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Friday unveiled a series of measures aimed at enhancing dignity, safety and economic opportunities for workers, signalling a comprehensive policy shift focused on grassroots impact.

Addressing a Workers’ Felicitation ceremony at Sant Nirankari Mandal in Dhirpur, the Chief Minister announced multiple initiatives, including free registration for construction workers, a new skill development programme, and improved service delivery through modern labour chowks and Shramik Seva Kendras.

Highlighting the role of workers in nation-building, she said, “Workers do not merely labour; they lay the foundation of the nation’s progress. The government’s responsibility is not limited to utilising their workforce, but extends to improving their quality of life, ensuring their safety and creating opportunities for their families.”

In a major relief measure, the government has waived the Rs 20 registration fee and Rs 5 renewal fee for building and construction workers. A ‘Collective Marriage Scheme’ was also announced to support workers with financial assistance and full arrangements for weddings.

The Chief Minister also emphasised strengthening social security systems, referring to platforms like the e-Shram portal, and said Delhi will expand access through a single-window system, on-site registration at labour chowks, Atal canteens offering meals at Rs 5, and mobile healthcare services.

During the event, safety kits were distributed to 1,000 workers, including helmets, gloves, masks and reflective jackets. Additionally, education kits



DIGNITY DRIVE

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were given to 100 children of registered workers studying in government schools.

Launching a major skill development initiative under the Recognition of Prior Learning (RPL) scheme, the Chief Minister announced that around 35,000 workers will be

trained annually in trades such as masonry, electrical work and carpentry. Initial batches have already been rolled out across districts. Reaffirming her government’s commitment, she said, “The Delhi government stands firmly with every worker. Ensuring their rights, dignity, safety and access to better opportunities is our core commitment. Respect for workers is respect for the nation.”

Labour Minister Kapil Mishra said, “After years, Delhi has a Chief Minister who stands shoulder to shoulder with workers. This marks a new sense of trust and a fresh beginning.”

The initiatives collectively aim to create a more inclusive and responsive labour welfare ecosystem in the capital.

Delhi Police bring 194 missing home

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police has traced and reunited 194 missing persons with their families in April, an official said on Friday.

This includes 45 missing or kidnapped children and 149 adults rescued between April 1 and April 30 this year, he said.

Under the ‘Operation Milap’, investigators relied on a combination of local intelligence and technical surveillance, including scanning CCTV footage and circulating photographs of the missing individuals at public places such as bus stands, railway stations, and auto and e-rickshaw stands.

To track movements,

enquiries were conducted with drivers, conductors, vendors and other local sources, while records of nearby police stations and hospitals were checked. Informers were also roped in to gather leads, the police said.

Among police stations, Kapashera reported one of the highest rescues tracing eight minor children and 21 adults, while Delhi Cantonment police traced 30 people, including one minor.

The police said that since the beginning of the year, a total of 542 missing persons, comprising 143 children and 399 adults, have been traced and reunited with their families in the district till April 30.

CJI ALSO DECLARED SIKKIM TO BE FIRST PAPERLESS STATE JUDICIARY

Tech integration into judicial processes dismantles geographical barriers: CJI

OUR CORRESPONDENT

GANGTOK: Chief Justice of India Surya Kant on Friday said integrating technology into judicial processes dismantles geographical barriers to help litigants overcome problems of terrain, finance and distance.

Addressing the inaugural session of the two-day National Conclave on Technology and Judicial Education here, the CJI also said the Indian legal landscape has moved away from the era of the paper trail, where vital records languished in physical storage, to a vibrant digital ecosystem.

He also declared Sikkim to be the first paperless state judiciary in the nation.

“When we speak of integrating technology into judicial processes across the country, we are, in effect, addressing the dismantling of geographical constraints, whether they arise from difficult terrain, financial barriers, or

Highlights

- » The journey to a courtroom was often measured as a test of endurance, the Chief Justice of India said
- » ‘We have moved away from the era of the paper trail, where vital records languished in physical storage, to a vibrant digital ecosystem’

sheer distance,” he said.

The journey to a courtroom was often measured as a test of endurance, the Chief Justice of India said.

“The mighty Himalayas, magnificent as they are, make movement slow and uncertain. If we look at the scenario just a decade or so ago, for a Sikkimese litigant seeking justice, distance was not measured in kilometres but in days of travel across narrow paths and unpredictable weather,” he said.

The CJI said digital reform is not a matter of theory, but a practical necessity for sustaining the rule of law.

“We have moved away from

the era of the paper trail, where vital records languished in physical storage, to a vibrant digital ecosystem. The e-Courts project has rewritten the relationship between the litigant and the law,” he said.

What once required physical presence and toilsome inquiry is now available through a simple digital interface, CJI Kant said, adding that in consonance with this advancement, the National Judicial Data Grid (NJDG) stands as the “beating heart” of this endeavour, offering a window into the pulse of our judicial performance.

“Beyond basic data collection, we have witnessed the

advent of intelligent assistance within our chambers,” he said, mentioning translation tool SUVAS and SUPACE, an AI-driven tool designed to assist judges.

“These innovations act as force multipliers, aiding in the swift translation of judgments and providing rapid, comprehensive research to the bench. They relieve the judge of the mechanical burden of routine inquiry, allowing for a deeper immersion in the complexities of the law,” the CJI said.

“When a litigant in the most distant corner of the country can track the progress of a case or view an order without intermediaries; if he can engage counsel from across the country and view proceedings in real time through video conferencing and live proceedings, the power dynamics of the courtroom undergo a healthy calibration,” he said.

Yet, it would be premature to assume that the task is complete,

said the Chief Justice of India.

He suggested that the large-scale digitisation achieved in trial courts through the National Core Case Information Systems (NC CIS) must now find a clear and consistent reflection in the higher judiciary through stronger standardisation.

“It enables High Courts to align with a common national standard while still accommodating state-specific requirements, whether in terms of nomenclature, local language needs, or procedural workflows,” he said.

The CJI said this standardisation exercise must also be accompanied by an expansion of e-Seva Kendras, one-stop digital service centres established in high courts and district courts to help litigants and lawyers access electronic court services such as assistance with case status, e-filing, obtaining certified copies, e-payments, and video conference hearings.

India hosts first BRICS Women’s Working Group preparatory meet

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Ministry of Women and Child Development convened the first preparatory meeting of the BRICS Women’s Working Group in virtual mode under India’s presidency of the intergovernmental grouping this year, officials said.

The meeting, held on April 30, reaffirmed India’s commitment to promoting women-led development, recognising them as key drivers of economic growth, governance and social transformation, according to the ministry.

Representatives from BRICS member countries participated in the meeting, along with officials from various ministries and departments of the Government of India. Knowledge partners, including UN Women and the Federation of Indian Chamber of Commerce and Industry (FICCI), also attended it, the ministry said.

Additional Secretary in the ministry Caralyn Khongwar

Deshmukh welcomed the delegates and set the tone for the discussions, it added.

Guided by the theme of India’s BRICS chairship -- “Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation, and Sustainability” -- the meeting focused on key global issues concerning women, which were grouped into four priority areas: women in governance and leadership; financial and digital inclusion; women’s entrepreneurship and skill development; and women’s role in climate action, food security and nutrition.

BRICS member nations, in their interventions, congratulated India on its chairship and expressed support for the identified priority areas, a ministry statement said.

The discussions will contribute to key outcomes to be finalised at the BRICS Women Working Group Meeting (July 6-7) and the BRICS Women Ministerial Meeting (July 8-9) to be held in Kochi, Kerala, the statement added.

Hyderabad: Six killed after car crashes into stationary lorry

OUR CORRESPONDENT

HYDERABAD: Six people, including a woman and three children, were killed after a speeding car hit a stationary lorry on the Outer Ring Road (ORR) here on Friday, police said.

The car crashed into the rear side of the lorry this afternoon, killing six people on the spot.

The lorry was stopped on the roadside to tighten the ropes securing the goods being transported, they said.

Seven people of a family were travelling in the car.

An injured woman (35) was undergoing treatment in a hospital and her condition was said to be serious.

The family was returning home in Sanatnagar here after a temple visit in neighbouring Yadadri-Bhuvanagiri district.

The victims belong to Sircilla town in Rajanna Sircilla district.

Tripura: Teenage girl found hanging at home, police detain grandfather

OUR CORRESPONDENT

AGARTALA: A 70-year-old man of Tripura’s Sepahijala district was detained on Friday after his granddaughter was found hanging from the ceiling in their house, police said.

A BJP Yuva Morcha leader and the neighbours alleged that the man sexually assaulted the 16-year-old girl, strangled her to death, and hanged her body to make it look like suicide.

They demanded capital punishment for the grandfather.

No formal complaint was lodged by the victim’s family, and the police registered an unnatural death case. “After being alerted, a police team reached their house on Thursday night

and recovered the body. Preliminary findings indicate it was a hanging case. The actual cause of death will be confirmed after receiving the post-mortem examination report,” Officer in Charge (OC) of Sonamura Police Station, Tapas Das, said over the telephone.

“The victim’s 70-year-old grandfather has been detained for interrogation,” he said.

The class 10 student used to live in the house with her grandfather and grandmother. Her parents live elsewhere.

Sukanta Sarkar, the president of the BJP Yuva Morcha unit of Nalchar Asama constituency, alleged that the girl was first raped and then murdered by her grandfather.

India shifts majority of gold reserves home amid geopolitical uncertainty

Continued from Page 1

That 197.67 metric tonnes of gold remained in custody with the Bank of England and the Bank for International Settlements, while 2.80 metric tonnes were held as gold deposits. This marks a clear reduction in overseas holdings compared with September 2025, when 290.37 metric tonnes were still stored abroad and 13.99 metric tonnes were held as deposits.

The shift in custody has been accompanied by a rise in the importance of gold within India’s overall reserve composition. The share of gold in total foreign exchange reserves increased to 16.7 per cent in March 2026, up from 13.92 per cent six months earlier, aided by a rally in global gold prices.

India’s total foreign exchange

reserves stood at about 691.1 billion dollars during this period.

Data on foreign currency assets showed that out of 552.28 billion dollars, 465.61 billion dollars were invested in securities, 46.83 billion dollars were deposited with other central banks and the BIS, and 39.84 billion dollars were held with commercial banks overseas. The deployment pattern saw minor adjustments, with a slight shift away from securities and commercial bank deposits toward placements with central banks and the BIS. The Reserve Bank’s net forward asset position was recorded at a payable of 103.06 billion dollars at the end of March 2026.

The pace of gold repatriation marks a continuation and acceleration of a strategy that began several years ago. In

March 2023, only about 37 per cent of India’s gold reserves were stored domestically. Since then, the share has steadily climbed, indicating a deliberate rebalancing of custody arrangements rather than an abrupt shift.

RBI officials have not framed the move as a departure from global financial centres but rather as a recalibration. India continues to maintain a portion of its gold abroad to ensure access to deep and liquid bullion markets, particularly in London, which remains a key hub for gold trading and settlement.

Historically, institutions such as the Bank of England and global financial centres like New York have served as trusted custodians for central bank gold, offering liquidity and ease of transactions. The Federal Reserve Bank of New

York, for instance, is estimated to hold more than 500,000 gold bars, while the Bank of England stores around 430,000 bars on behalf of multiple countries. These arrangements allowed central banks to trade gold efficiently without physically moving it.

However, recent global developments have prompted policymakers to reconsider the balance between convenience and control. Events such as the freezing of sovereign assets following the Russia-Ukraine conflict and earlier actions involving Afghanistan’s reserves have introduced new concerns about access to assets held abroad. While gold itself has not broadly been subject to such restrictions, the precedent has influenced central bank thinking.

India’s approach reflects

this changing environment. By increasing domestic storage, the country ensures quicker access to its reserves in times of financial stress while still retaining some exposure to international markets. Analysts say gold is increasingly viewed not just as a financial asset but also as a form of strategic insurance, where physical control plays a critical role.

The trend is not unique to India. Countries across Europe and beyond have begun adjusting their gold storage strategies, though at varying speeds. Some, like France, have shifted portions of their reserves back home, while others such as Germany continue to maintain a substantial share abroad despite periodic political debate. Nations like Poland have adopted a mixed model, combining domestic storage with

continued use of international vaults.

India’s latest move underscores a broader shift in how central banks define financial safety. For decades, trust in established global custodians formed the backbone of reserve management. Increasingly, that trust is being balanced with a preference for direct control.

Even as the global gold storage system centred around London and New York remains operational and influential, the assumptions underpinning it are evolving. Countries are no longer focused solely on the security of their reserves but also on assured access during periods of geopolitical or economic uncertainty. India’s rapid repatriation highlights how that calculation is changing, placing greater weight on sovereignty over proximity.

From Page 1

TMC’s plea

before the high court that the communication was issued without jurisdiction and was based on mere apprehension.

The EC’s counsel had contended before the high court that the Representation of the People Act, 1951, allows delegation of the commission’s functions and that the directive was valid.

The poll panel’s counsel had also submitted that the communication was issued on April 13, but the petition was filed only on April 30, close to the counting date, alleging that the move was intended to stall the process.

The high court had not agreed with the TMC’s allegation that its main opponent, the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), controls the employees of the central government or PSUs, making them susceptible to suggestions and control by the Union government.

It had also noted that apart from the counting supervisors and assistants, micro-observers, counting agents of candidates and other personnel would also be present in the counting hall.

Repolling

Allegations of electoral malpractice had been raised by the Bharatiya Janata Party in parts of these constituencies, which fall under the Diamond Harbour parliamentary seat represented by Abhishek Banerjee of the Trinamool Congress. In response, the poll body had deputed special observer Subrata Gupta to verify the claims on the ground.

Reacting to the development, TMC spokesperson Kunal Ghosh said the demand for repoll stemmed from political calculations. “The BJP knows it will be defeated by a big margin in Diamond Harbour and Magrahat. With the EC’s assistance, they are forcing voters to undergo the process again. The mandate will remain unchanged,” he said.

Meanwhile, senior BJP leader

Suvendu Adhikari welcomed the decision. “There had been malpractices in several booths to favour the TMC. We are satisfied with the EC’s move,” he said.

Khera

Subsequent investigation by the prosecution indicated that the documents were fake and had been used to defame the complainant, who later filed criminal cases under provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita at the Guwahati Crime Branch police station.

In granting relief, the court underscored the importance of personal liberty under Article 21 of the Constitution, stating that any deprivation must meet a higher threshold, particularly where surrounding circumstances suggest political overtones. “The right to personal liberty is a cherished fundamental right,” the bench observed, adding that courts must strike a careful balance between the state’s interest in a fair investigation and an individual’s liberty.

The court directed that Khera be released on anticipatory bail in the event of arrest, subject to reasonable conditions imposed by the investigating officer. These include cooperating with the investigation, appearing before the police when required, refraining from influencing witnesses or tampering with evidence, and not leaving the country without prior permission from the competent court. It also allowed the trial court to impose additional conditions if necessary.

Significantly, the bench took note of remarks made by Sarma during the same period, describing some of them as “unparliamentary” and relevant to understanding the broader context of the dispute. Among the statements cited in the order were remarks in which the Chief Minister allegedly said he would “turn Pawan Khera into ‘Pawan Peda’,” vowed to “drag him out” even if he hid, and suggested that Khera could face prolonged imprisonment if the ruling party returned to power. The court noted that Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the State of Assam, did not defend or dispute these statements during

the hearing.

“We cannot lose sight of the fact that the Chief Minister...has made certain unparliamentary remarks against the appellant,” the bench observed, adding that these comments formed part of the factual background indicating political rivalry between the two leaders.

The court said that both sides had engaged in allegations and counter-allegations in the public domain during the election campaign. In this context, it found that the criminal proceedings appeared, prima facie, to be influenced by political exchanges rather than circumstances requiring custodial interrogation. “The allegations and counter-allegations...appear to be politically motivated,” the order noted, while clarifying that the veracity of the claims would be tested during trial.

At the same time, the bench stressed that the investigation must proceed in accordance with law and with full cooperation from Khera. It reiterated that the criminal process should be applied with objectivity and circumspection to ensure that individual liberty is not jeopardised by proceedings that may be coloured by political rivalry.

The court also observed that the chief minister had, in separate statements, made remarks against Khera, which were placed on record by the defence. This, it said, further highlighted the contentious political backdrop of the case.

Earlier in the proceedings, the Telangana High Court had granted Khera a seven-day transit anticipatory bail, which was challenged by Assam Police before the apex court. The Supreme Court had stayed that relief and directed Khera to approach the Gauhati High Court before ultimately granting him protection from arrest.

The bench clarified that its observations were limited to the question of anticipatory bail and would not affect the merits of the criminal case, which will be decided independently during trial.

LPG

Hormuz, a key route for global energy shipments, remains

effectively shut for a third month, tightening availability and pushing up costs.

While commercial fuel users face higher costs, domestic consumers and airlines have been shielded from immediate price increases. Aviation turbine fuel for domestic airlines has been kept unchanged at Rs 1,04,927.18 per kilolitre, with state-owned oil companies absorbing the rise in international prices.

However, for international carriers, aviation fuel prices were increased by USD 76.55 per kilolitre, or 5.33 per cent, to USD 1,511.86 per kl. This follows a sharp rise in April when rates for overseas airlines were more than doubled.

The decision to hold domestic ATF prices steady is expected to ease pressure on carriers such as Air India, IndiGo and SpiceJet, which have flagged rising fuel costs as a major concern. The Federation of Indian Airlines had earlier said that aviation fuel expenses had risen from 30–40 per cent of operating costs to as much as 55–60 per cent, making operations difficult.

In another revision, bulk diesel prices used by industrial consumers such as telecom towers were increased from about Rs 137 per litre to over Rs 149 per litre. In contrast, retail diesel prices remain unchanged at Rs 87.62 per litre, while petrol continues to be sold at Rs 94.72 per litre in Delhi.

According to Indian Oil Corporation, there has been no change in petrol, diesel, domestic LPG and kerosene prices, insulating a large section of consumers from global price volatility. These fuels together account for more than 80 per cent of total consumption in the country.

“Price revisions have been limited to select industrial segments, which constitute a relatively small share of overall consumption and are subject to routine monthly adjustments based on prevailing international prices,” the company said.

Oil firms added that commercial LPG and bulk diesel account for a small portion of total fuel usage, with commercial LPG alone making up less than 1 per cent. Around 80 per cent of petroleum products have seen no change in prices, while about 4 per cent have recorded a reduc-

tion, reflecting fluctuations in global benchmarks.

Despite holding prices for key fuels, oil companies are facing financial pressure. Industry estimates suggest under-recoveries of around Rs 14 per litre on petrol and Rs 18 per litre on diesel. Losses are also expected on domestic LPG and aviation fuel sold to domestic airlines.

These losses are likely to be offset through future gains if global prices ease or through government support, particularly in the case of domestic LPG subsidies.

India deregulated jet fuel prices more than two decades ago, linking them to international benchmarks. However, the recent surge in global energy prices has led to a more gradual pass-through, with domestic airlines protected even as global rates continue to rise.

Punjab Assembly

The confidence vote comes after a political setback on April 24, when seven of AAP’s 10 Rajya Sabha MPs, including Raghav Chadha, Sandeep Pathak and Harbhajan Singh, resigned and joined the BJP.

Six of the defecting MPs were from Punjab. Rajya Sabha Chairman C P Radhakrishnan later accepted the merger, reducing AAP’s strength in the Upper House to three.

During the session, Mann pointed to the party’s presence across states, citing representation in Punjab, Delhi, Gujarat, Goa and Jammu and Kashmir. He said the party continues to expand and has elected representatives at various levels.

Several party leaders reiterated their support. Finance Minister Harpal Singh Cheema, who seconded the motion, criticised the BJP-led central government over the defections and accused it of misusing central agencies. Other MLAs said they would remain committed to the party and stand by its leadership.

Alongside the confidence vote, the Assembly passed a resolution approving a 15 per cent increase in minimum wages,

marking the first revision of the base rate since 2012. Mann described the move as a tribute to workers, noting that while dearness allowance had increased over time, the base wage had not been revised for more than a decade.

Highlighting development measures, the chief minister said 359 students from government schools had cleared the Joint Entrance Examination, many of them from labourer families. He said education would play a key role in improving their socio-economic conditions.

The Assembly also passed the Jaagat Jot Sri Guro Granth Sahib Satkar Amendment Act 2026, which prescribes stricter punishment for sacrilege. Mann announced that he would undertake a “Shukrana Yatra” from May 6 to May 9, visiting key religious sites to express gratitude following the passage of the legislation.

Criticising the opposition, Mann said the Congress walkout reflected a lack of engagement with workers’ issues. He also dismissed opposition demands, including calls for an alcohol test, saying they had no substantive issues to raise.

The developments during the session come at a significant time for the AAP government as it seeks to reinforce stability following recent changes in its representation at the national level.

Noida Airport

air travel in the region. Officials said the facility combines modern terminal infrastructure with efficient operations and seamless multimodal connectivity, aimed at ensuring a smooth passenger experience while offering airlines cost-effective operations.

The launch of commercial services is expected to significantly enhance regional connectivity and reduce congestion at Delhi’s Indira Gandhi International Airport.

It is also seen as a major step towards strengthening economic growth by boosting tourism, trade, and investment opportunities in Uttar Pradesh and adjoining regions.

Noida International Airport, with IATA code DXN, is being developed by Yamuna International Airport Private Limited (YIAPL), a wholly owned subsidiary of Zurich Airport International AG, under a public-private partnership model. The project is being executed in collaboration with the Uttar Pradesh and central governments.

In its first phase, the airport will have one runway and a passenger terminal with an annual capacity of 12 million passengers. As per the master plan, it will be expanded in phases to handle up to 70 million passengers annually over the 40-year concession period that began in October 2021.

Positioned as a world-class greenfield airport, it aims to combine Swiss efficiency with Indian hospitality, while also working towards a net-zero emissions goal through sustainable design and operations.

IMD

the country,” he said. However, he added that parts of northwest India, along with some central regions and adjoining peninsular areas, as well as southern sections of the northeast, could experience normal to below-normal night temperatures.

The IMD also indicated that the southwest monsoon is likely to reach the Andaman and Nicobar Islands between May 14 and 16, marking the seasonal progression of rains.

On broader climate conditions, the department noted that ENSO-neutral conditions in the equatorial Pacific are shifting toward El Niño, a phase linked to warming ocean waters.

The Monsoon Mission Coupled Forecasting System suggests that El Niño conditions may develop during the upcoming southwest monsoon season.

Looking back at April, the IMD reported that most regions recorded normal to below-normal daytime temperatures, except southern peninsular India, where temperatures were above average. The country also experienced seven western disturbances during the month.

‘UT REMAINS PM MODI’S FOCUS’

Rapid transformation in Ladakh since 2019: Shah

OUR CORRESPONDENT

LEH/JAMMU: Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Friday highlighted Ladakh as a model of rapid transformation since its creation as a Union Territory in 2019, citing wide-ranging political, social and economic changes, while also launching key development initiatives and attending a major cultural event on Buddha Purnima.

Shah said Ladakh, which had long demanded Union Territory status due to lack of development, has witnessed visible progress across sectors since the bifurcation of the erstwhile Jammu and Kashmir in August 2019, when Article 370 was abrogated. He noted that the region remains a priority in the development agenda of Prime Minister Narendra Modi. Highlighting administrative changes, he said Ladakh now has seven districts and 193 panchayats, with five new districts—Sham,



Union Home Minister Amit Shah offers prayers during the inauguration of the first international exposition of holy relics of Lord Buddha in Ladakh

Nubra, Changthang, Zaskar and Drass—created. Local languages such as Bhoti, Purgi and Urdu have also been given administrative recognition alongside Hindi and English.

Detailing infrastructure growth, Shah said road length has increased from about

1,799 km before 2019 to over 4,040 km, while the number of bridges has risen from 19 to 72. Mobile towers have nearly doubled from 344 to 653, helipads have increased from seven to 41, and snow-clearing machines from 60 to 215. He said improved connectiv-

HIGHLIGHTS

- » Shah said Ladakh has witnessed visible progress across sectors since the bifurcation of the erstwhile J&K
- » He laid the foundation stone of a 10,000 litres-per-day dairy plant in Kargil
- » Shah also inaugurated the exposition of holy Buddha relics in Leh

ity has significantly reduced winter road closures, with key routes like Zojila Pass and the Kargil-Leh road remaining open for longer durations.

He added that major projects such as the Zojila tunnel and the Shinkun La tunnel are underway, along with a new civil airport. Power infrastructure has also expanded, with grid-related works ris-

ing from 145 to 184 and distribution transformers from 1,182 to 3,153. VSAT connectivity has been extended to all panchayats.

In the social sector, Shah said Sindhu Central University has been established, along with 174 ICT labs, 130 smart classrooms, 40 science laboratories and 24 Atal Tinkering Labs. He stated that Ladakh became a fully literate administrative unit in 2024 and that nearly 98 per cent of households now have tap water connections under the Har Ghar Jal scheme. The Union Territory's budget has increased from around Rs 1,000 crore to Rs 6,000 crore, he added, also announcing the formation of the Sindhu Infrastructure Development Corporation to promote industrial growth.

As part of development initiatives, Shah laid the foundation stone of a 10,000 litres-per-day dairy plant in Kargil and launched multiple mea-

sures to strengthen the dairy sector. The plant, being set up with support from the National Dairy Development Board, will operate on a solar energy-based system. Initiatives such as mobile milk testing laboratories, modern cooling systems and digital procurement mechanisms aim to improve efficiency, transparency and farmer incomes. Officials said the dairy network has expanded from 74 farmers in a single village to around 1,700 farmers, with daily milk collection reaching nearly 7,000 litres and cumulative payments crossing Rs 15 crore.

On the occasion of Buddha Purnima, Shah inaugurated an exposition of sacred relics of Gautama Buddha in Leh, calling it a historic moment for Ladakh. The Home minister noted the region's deep-rooted Buddhist heritage and its role in preserving and spreading Buddhist teachings across regions such as Central Asia.

MP's Bargi Dam cruise boat tragedy: Death toll rises to 9

Survivors allege 'lapses' in safety protocols



SATYAPRAKASH SHARMA

BHOPAL: The death toll in the tragic capsizing of a Madhya Pradesh Tourism-operated cruise boat in the Bargi Dam reservoir rose to nine on Friday, as rescue teams recovered five more bodies in the early hours of the day.

The incident occurred on Thursday evening when the boat, carrying around 29 tourists and two crew members, suddenly overturned due to a severe storm, accompanied by strong winds and high waves, in the Narmada backwaters near Khamariya Island. The vessel sank rapidly, triggering a large-scale rescue operation.

Tourism minister Dharmendra Bhav Singh Lodhi said that four bodies were recovered on Thursday, while five were found in the early hours of Friday, taking the toll to nine. As many as 22 people have been rescued so far, he added.

According to officials, search operations by teams from the NDRF, SDRF, Army divers, and local police continued on Friday to trace any remaining missing persons.

Survivors have alleged lapses in safety protocols, claiming that life jackets were not properly distributed before the trip and were handed out only after the boat began tilting, leading to panic.

One emotional account

described rescuers finding a mother and her four-year-old son's bodies still clutched together inside the sunken vessel. They were part of a family of four tourists from Delhi; the father and daughter managed to escape the horrific accident.

The Bargi Dam is located on the Narmada River in Jabalpur district.

On Friday, Chief Minister Mohan Yadav rushed to the spot and met grieving family members as well as rescued tourists who had been hospitalised. The CM expressed deep sorrow and announced Rs 4 lakh compensation for the families of each deceased. He said senior ministers, including Public Works minister Rakesh Singh and Tourism minister Lodhi, were personally monitoring the rescue and relief operations.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi condoled the tragedy and announced ex gratia of Rs 2 lakh from the PM National Relief Fund for the kin of each deceased and Rs 50,000 for the injured.

In response to the incident, the state government has ordered a high-level probe into possible negligence and has banned all cruise boat operations across the state until further notice. The Tourism minister assured strict action if any safety violations are found.

UP: Ganga Expressway to remain toll free for 15 days after opening

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

LUCKNOW: In a major relief for commuters, Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath has announced that the Ganga Expressway will remain toll free for 15 days from its Commercial Operation Date.

The decision has been taken to allow the public to experience the state's longest expressway without any charge during its initial phase of operation.

Following the Chief Minister's directive, the Uttar Pradesh Expressways Industrial Development Authority issued instructions to concessionaires, including IRB Infrastructure and Adani Infrastructure, to suspend toll collection for the specified period. Officials confirmed that no user fee will be charged from

The initiative aims to familiarise commuters with the high-speed corridor

commuters during these 15 days.

The move comes after the Independent Engineer issued a provisional completion certificate under the concession agreement, formally marking the Commercial Operation Date and clearing the expressway for public use.

Officials said the initiative is aimed at encouraging maximum public participation and familiarising commuters with the high-speed corridor. The 594-kilometre-long expressway will allow users to assess travel time, road quality and facilities

firsthand. Developed under the Public Private Partnership model on a DBFOT toll basis, the project grants concessionaires toll collection rights for 27 years. However, the state government or UPEIDA will compensate the developers for revenue losses incurred during the toll-free period, in line with contractual provisions.

Authorities have clarified that operational standards will remain unaffected. Maintenance, safety protocols, traffic management and public amenities will continue to be enforced as per the agreement.

Stretching from Meerut to Prayagraj, the expressway passes through 12 districts and is being projected as a key driver of economic growth and connectivity in Uttar Pradesh.

Saini says Punjab needs 'stability, development-oriented leadership'

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Friday urged people in Punjab to back the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, asserting that stronger alignment with the Centre would accelerate the state's growth. Addressing industrialists in Mandi Gobindgarh, he said Punjab could regain its economic strength under a stable and development-focused government.

Criticising the AAP-led dispensation, Saini alleged that industries in Punjab face regulatory hurdles, power shortages and law-and-order concerns, while Haryana has advanced through investor-friendly policies and improved infrastructure. He highlighted measures



such as simplified procedures, a single-window clearance system and upgraded utilities, which have helped attract investment to Haryana.

Saini said initiatives like Make in India, Startup India and Digital India have reshaped the country's industrial landscape. He added that Haryana is preparing a new industrial policy in consultation with stakeholders and has

Initiatives like Make in India, Startup India and Digital India have reshaped the country's industrial landscape

scrapped over 1,100 outdated rules to improve ease of doing business. The Chief Minister outlined upcoming measures, including a 'Land Feasibility Certificate' system, expansion of industrial model townships, and plug-and-play facilities for quicker project execution. He also announced insurance support for MSMEs and faster dispute resolution mechanisms.

Punjab Chief Secy urges citizens to take part in Census drive

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Punjab Chief Secretary KAP Sinha has completed his self-enumeration for Census 2027 through the official online portal, setting an example for citizens to participate in the national exercise. The process at his residence was facilitated by Secretary, Local Government Manjit Singh Brar and Director, Census Punjab and Chandigarh Navjot Khosa.

Sinha urged residents across the state to actively take part in the Census, describing it as a key civic responsibility that helps assess public needs and ensures fair allocation of resources. He emphasised that every household must be counted so that no section of society is left out of development planning.

Highlighting the importance of accurate data, the Chief Secretary said Census findings form the basis for planning infrastructure such as schools, hospitals, roads and welfare schemes.

He added that public participation is essential for building a more inclusive and developed India.

Self-enumeration is a key feature of Census 2027 and will be conducted from April 30 to May 14, 2026 in Punjab. It enables individuals to conveniently submit their demographic and socio-economic details online from the comfort of their homes.

Emphasising its importance, he stated that self-enumeration is vital for conducting a credible and inclusive Census, as it allows citizens to directly contribute to nation-building through accurate representation of their family, community, and region.

This initiative significantly reduces the need for physical interaction while enhancing the efficiency, coverage, and reliability of data collection. It will be followed by the House-listing Phase from May 15 to June 13, 2026.

Can't hear or see, but Lucknow girl scores 98% in Class 12 exam

LUCKNOW: In a story that reads more like a testament to human will than an examination result, Sarah Moin of Lucknow has turned adversity into academic brilliance, securing 98.75 per cent marks (best of four subjects) in the ISC Class 12 examinations.

The 19-year-old, who lives with both visual and hearing impairment and is battling a rare condition such as sarcoidosis, emerged as one of the top performers in her school, scoring 98.2 per cent in her best of five subjects.

Her result includes perfect 100 marks each in Geography and Mass Media & Communication, 98 in English, 97 in History and 96 in Psychology, along with an A grade in SUPW and Community Service.

Sarah, a resident of the Hus-

sain Ganj area, comes from a family including her father, Moin Ahmad Idris, her mother, Julee Hamid, and an elder brother who serves as a high court lawyer. For her, conventional classrooms were never the standard.

She studied at Christ Church College under Principal Rakesh Chatterjee and special educator Salman Ali Qazi, with support that extended beyond textbooks into communication, accessibility and daily learning tools.

She uses assistive technologies such as a Braille display and Orbit Reader, which convert digital content into a readable tactile format. At home too, she continues her studies using similar devices that allow her to read, write and interact with a computer independently.

Teachers and classmates

have long drawn parallels between her resilience and that of Helen Keller, often referring to her by that name, according to her father.

Helen Keller was an American author, lecturer and disability rights advocate who overcame blindness and deafness to become one of the most influential voices for persons with disabilities worldwide. Her life continues to be cited globally as an example of overcoming severe sensory impairment through education and determination.

Her father, Moin Ahmad Idris, said that despite her achievements, appearing in competitive examinations remains a major hurdle due to a lack of adequate accessibility provisions for deaf-blind candidates.

AGENCIES

AGENCY'S POWERS, APPROACH UNDER RENEWED SCRUTINY

PMLA cases: ED at centre of legal debate

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: The Enforcement Directorate (ED) is at the centre of a widening legal debate that could shape the future of money laundering prosecutions in India. As courts revisit key interpretations, the scope of the agency's powers and its approach to financial crimes are under renewed scrutiny.

The discussion has gained momentum after courts granted relief to AAP leader Arvind Kejriwal in a CBI probe linked to the liquor policy case. This has raised questions about whether developments in a predicate offence can influence parallel money laundering cases, even though the two are treated as separate under law. The ED continues to assert that money laundering is an independent offence, irrespective of the outcome of the underlying case. However, some legal experts argue that the absence of proven wrongdoing in the base case could weaken the prosecution's position.

ED Director Rahul Navin has indicated that the issue points to structural gaps in India's anti-money laundering framework. Amendments to the Preven-

ED shifts focus on new-age financial crimes

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: Enforcement Directorate (ED) Director Rahul Navin on Friday said the agency is increasingly focusing on emerging financial threats, including cryptocurrency frauds, terror financing networks and cyber-enabled economic crimes. He added that illicit money flows linked to drug trafficking are also under closer watch as patterns of financial crime evolve.

Speaking at the 70th ED Day event, Navin noted a decline in traditional economic offences such as real estate and banking-related scams, attributing the shift to reforms like the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code and stricter housing regulations. These changes, he said, have



strengthened oversight and reduced violations in sectors once prone to fraud.

Highlighting performance, he said the ED filed 812 prosecution complaints in 2025-26 along with 155 supplementary chargesheets, while maintaining a conviction rate of around 94 per cent. Of nearly 2,400 pending money laundering cases, he expressed confidence

in favourable outcomes.

Navin also said assets worth over Rs 63,000 crore have been restored to victims. The ED, established in 1956, enforces laws including the Prevention of Money Laundering Act and the Fugitive Economic Offenders Act, adapting its approach to tackle increasingly digital and cross-border financial crimes.

have been targeted for recovery. Critics, however, question whether such powers align with principles of fairness, especially when the primary charges remain unproven. Separately,

under the Fugitive Economic Offenders Act, proceedings have been initiated against 54 individuals, with 21 declared fugitives and assets worth Rs 2,178 crore confiscated.

NCB seizes cocaine worth Rs 1,745 cr in Mumbai

NARESH BISWANI

MUMBAI: In one of the biggest anti-narcotics operations in recent years, the Narcotics Control Bureau (NCB) has seized 349 kg of high-grade cocaine valued at approximately Rs 1,745 crore, dismantling a major transnational drug trafficking network under "Operation White Strike". The operation unfolded over several weeks through intelligence sharing between maritime units and customs authorities.

Cargo containers arriving from South America were flagged based on tracking patterns analysed by enforcement teams. Evidence indicates the involvement of international intermediaries who used commercial freight consignments to conceal the contraband. Investigations are continuing into financial links connected to storage facilities near

INSIGHT

- » The operation unfolded over several weeks through intelligence sharing between maritime units and customs authorities
- » Cargo containers arriving from South America were flagged based on tracking patterns analysed by enforcement teams



Nhava Sheva, while identities are being verified through biometric databases. The findings highlight vulnerabilities within global shipping systems that were exploited.

After months of information gathering, officials carried out coordinated raids along the Kalamboli-Bhiwandi supply route near Navi Mumbai and Thane. Surveillance had established movement patterns before the action. In the first phase, officers intercepted a transport vehicle near Kalamboli and recovered 136 pack-

ets of cocaine, each weighing about one kilogram. The contraband was hidden inside boxes along with sports equipment such as batting pads and gloves. One suspect was taken into custody at the site.

Further questioning led investigators to a second location in Bhiwandi, a major warehousing hub. At this facility, authorities recovered an additional 213 kg of cocaine from within concealed compartments. The substance matched earlier samples, linking both seizures through shared logis-

tics trails. Monitoring over several days enabled the recovery without alerting those involved.

Officials found that the drugs were packed in multiple plastic layers coated with a substance intended to evade detection.

The concealment methods pointed to a structured system involving import, storage and movement across locations. Distribution appeared to be planned in multiple stages, indicating coordination across the network.

INLD leader slams Haryana govt over Power charges



CHANDIGARH: Former Haryana minister and INLD national patron Sampat Singh on Friday accused the BJP-led state government of burdening consumers through repeated hikes in electricity charges.

Addressing a press conference here, he alleged that a surcharge of 47 paise per unit has already been imposed and power distribution companies are now seeking further levies.

Singh said he has filed a petition before the Haryana Electricity Regulatory Commission opposing the proposed Fuel Surcharge Adjustment (FSA) for 2025-26, terming it "legally untenable". He urged the commission to reject the demand and take action against distribution licensees for alleged regulatory violations.

A public hearing on the matter is scheduled for May 14. MPOST

Nation Briefs

RAILWAY BOARD MEMBER REVIEWS ONGOING PROJECTS IN NFR



MALIGAON: Vivek Kumar Gupta, Member (Infrastructure), Railway Board, visited Northeast Frontier Railway (NFR) and held a comprehensive review meeting at Maligaon to assess the progress of ongoing infrastructure projects and development works across the zone. The meeting was attended by NFR General Manager Chetan Kumar Shrivastava and General Manager (Construction) Ashish Bansal, along with other senior officials of NFR. Gupta will undertake a comprehensive window trailing inspection on Saturday from Kamakhya to Dimapur to review track conditions, safety measures and infrastructure status along the route. At Dimapur, he is scheduled to review on progress of the Dimapur-Kohima new line railway project.

HRY OFFICIAL SACKED OVER 'SCAM'

CHANDIGARH: The Haryana government has dismissed Rajesh Sangwan, Controller Finance and Accounts with the Haryana State Agricultural Marketing Board, over his alleged involvement in a financial scam. The action was taken under Article 311(2)(b) of the Constitution. Sangwan was arrested on March 14, 2026, by the Vigilance and Anti-Corruption Bureau.



EDITORIAL
BEYOND
LEGAL
RESTITUTION

The return of 657 antiquities from the United States to India, valued at nearly USD 14 million, is more than a diplomatic gesture or a legal victory. It is, in many ways, a homecoming—one that restores fragments of a civilisation’s memory that had been scattered across continents through theft, deceit, and indifference. Each artefact that returns carries not just monetary worth, but a story interrupted, a legacy displaced, and now, finally, a chance at restitution. For decades, India’s cultural heritage has been vulnerable to organised trafficking networks that treated sacred objects and historical artefacts as commodities. The recent recovery—facilitated by the Manhattan District Attorney’s Office and supported by US law enforcement agencies—highlights both the scale of the problem and the persistence required to address it. That more than 6,200 cultural objects have been recovered globally through these efforts is encouraging, but the accompanying admission that “more work remains” is equally telling. The battle is far from over.

Consider, for instance, the journey of the bronze Avalokiteshvara statue, valued at USD 2 million. Once part of a revered collection near Raipur, it was stolen, smuggled out of India, and eventually found its way into a private collection in New York. For decades, it existed in exile, detached from the cultural and spiritual context that gave it meaning. Its return is not just a matter of legal correction; it is a restoration of continuity. The same can be said of the sandstone Ganesha statue looted from a temple in Madhya Pradesh, passed through illicit hands, and ultimately sold with fabricated provenance at a prestigious auction house. These are not isolated incidents—they are emblematic of a larger, systemic plunder.

What makes such trafficking particularly troubling is the deliberate erasure of origin. False documentation, forged ownership histories, and the complicity of dealers and galleries create a parallel narrative where stolen artefacts are stripped of their identity. In this shadow economy, a deity becomes an object, a relic becomes décor, and history becomes negotiable. The conviction of traffickers like Subhash Kapoor and Nancy Wiener exposes the machinery behind this trade, but it also raises uncomfortable questions about the demand that sustains it. Without willing buyers, the chain would break. Yet, the allure of possessing a piece of antiquity—however acquired—continues to fuel the market. The role of international cooperation in reversing this trend cannot be overstated. The collaboration between Indian authorities and agencies such as the US Department of Homeland Security demonstrates what is possible when political will aligns with institutional commitment. It also sets a precedent for other nations that hold, knowingly or otherwise, artefacts of dubious origin. Restitution must become not an exception, but an expectation.

At the same time, the conversation must turn inward. India’s own mechanisms for protecting its heritage require constant strengthening. Museums, temples, and archaeological sites often remain under-resourced and inadequately secured, making them easy targets. Documentation and digitisation of collections, stricter monitoring of art markets, and community awareness are critical steps in ensuring that history is not lost again. Prevention, after all, is more effective than recovery. There is also a deeper, more philosophical dimension to these returns. Cultural artefacts are not merely objects of the past; they are anchors of identity. In a country as diverse as India, where traditions overlap and histories intertwine, such artefacts serve as shared reference points. They remind us of who we were, how we evolved, and what we continue to value. When they are stolen, it is not just a physical loss—it is a disruption of cultural continuity. The return of these antiquities, therefore, should be seen as an opportunity to renew our engagement with heritage. It is a moment to move beyond pride in recovery and towards responsibility in preservation. Schools, cultural institutions, and media must play a role in reconnecting people with these objects, not as distant relics behind glass, but as living symbols of a collective past.

At a global level, the issue also calls for a rethinking of how museums and private collectors approach provenance. The old argument—that artefacts are better preserved in foreign collections—no longer holds moral ground. Preservation cannot come at the cost of displacement, nor can appreciation justify appropriation. The ethics of ownership must evolve to recognise that cultural heritage belongs, first and foremost, to the communities that created it. There is, in the end, something profoundly human about the act of return. It acknowledges wrongdoing, corrects injustice, and restores a sense of balance. But it also demands vigilance. As long as there are networks willing to exploit heritage for profit, and buyers willing to overlook origins, the cycle will persist. The 657 artefacts that have come back are a beginning, not a conclusion. They stand as both a victory and a reminder—that history, once lost, can be reclaimed, but only through sustained effort, cooperation, and a shared commitment to honouring the past.

STATE
WATCH



SHANTANU MUKHARJI
THE WRITER IS
A RETIRED IPS
OFFICER, ADVISER
NATSTRAT, AND A
FORMER NATIONAL
SECURITY ADVISOR
IN MAURITIUS

The persistence of mob violence across regimes indicates that the problem is not episodic governance failure but a deeper societal shift

It has been nearly three months since Prime Minister Tarique Rahman assumed office, raising hopes among Bangladeshis for a new Bangladesh that would promise a better life, a secure environment, and cordial relations with all, among other positive measures the Prime Minister embarked upon. The minorities, in particular—including the Hindus, Shias, the Adhamiyas, and others—felt reassured that their places of worship would no longer be vandalised by religious fanatics. Tarique Rahman also gave clear directives to his government to ensure that all felt reassured as far as the safety of their lives and property was concerned. However, a recent solitary incident dashed these flickering hopes when, on April 11, a Sufi Pir, Shamim al-Jahangir, was lynched inside his shrine in Kushtia. A mob vandalised and set aflame the shrine following allegations spread on social media over an old video that was claimed to contain derogatory remarks about religious sentiments. Police recovered the victim from the scene in a critical condition and rushed him to a hospital, where he was declared dead on arrival.

Likewise, just a day before the Kushtia killing, several people, including women, were assaulted and harassed in Dhaka’s Shahbagh by a group operating under the name “Azadi Andolon,” which had branded the victims as being homosexual. The pattern is typical: it has become easy to mount attacks—even fatal ones—against anyone simply for holding, or even seeming to hold, different ideologies, faiths, or liberal opinions. Meanwhile, according to the Human Rights Support Society (HRSS), at least 49 people were killed in mob violence and lynching incidents across Bangladesh in just the first three months of 2026, across 88 separate incidents. Some of these incidents were sparked by accusations of theft or robbery, others by personal disputes, and increasingly by allegations of religious insults circulated on internet platforms. These statistics lead one to form an opinion as to how perilous social media has become, taking a toll on innocent lives. In fact, the trend of mob attacks on shrines becomes more disturbing when seen over a slightly longer timeline.

Further, a recent study by the Maqam Center for Sufi Heritage, disclosed in February, documented 97 attacks on shrines across the country between August 2024 and December 2025, leaving three dead and 468 injured. Despite the scale of violence, only 11 cases were filed, and investigations in 10 of those cases showed “no progress.” In many instances, victims were beaten, displaced, or forced to abandon the shrines altogether, leaving them in no position to even pursue legal action. The study further found



49 have been killed in mob violence across 88 incidents in the first three months of 2026 in Bangladesh

that most attacks were carried out by mobs under banners such as “tawhidi janata,” with alleged involvement of political activists. In some cases, attackers even used bulldozers and loudspeakers to mobilise crowds and destroy shrines. According to Jannatul Naym Pieal, a researcher and a well-known journalist, apart from shrines, Baul practitioners, cultural events, and artistic spaces have repeatedly been targeted in recent times. These are not random victims; they represent a long tradition of pluralism in Bengal’s religious and cultural life—spaces where faith, music, and local traditions have historically coexisted. What makes these spaces particularly vulnerable today is not just ideological hostility, but a growing sense of social permission allowing it. Over time, a form of collective consent has been manufactured—through sermons, online videos, informal local preaching networks, and social media bots—that frames shrines and similar institutions

as being anti-Islamic. Once that perception takes root, attacks are no longer perceived by some as violations, but as corrections. This sense of permissibility is reinforced in more subtle ways as well, including through the language of mainstream media. In the Kushtia case, many outlets were quick to describe the victim as a “so-called” or “self-proclaimed” Pir, or to place the word Pir within quotes. On the surface, this may appear as an attempt at neutrality or scepticism. But, in effect, it introduces a dangerous ambiguity—as if the legitimacy of a spiritual identity has any bearing on whether killing a person can ever be justified. There was, in fact, little journalistic necessity to foreground or question in headlines whether the Pir was “legitimate” or not; careful wording could have conveyed the facts without inserting doubt over his identity. If international agencies such as Agence France-Presse (AFP) can use descriptors like “spiritual leader” to cover this

news, what prevents local media from adopting the same standard of clarity and restraint? These questions are being asked by Pieal, the journalist under reference. According to “Daily Star,” the most widely read English daily in Bangladesh, the persistent attacks on shrines, even under the current government, expose another uncomfortable truth. During the interim government, such violence was often attributed to weak governance and a lack of willingness to take firm action. The continuation of the same pattern of violence under a different, elected authority proves that this explanation was incomplete. Mob violence did not suddenly originate within the interim government, as stated by a rights organisation in February this year; rather, it became more visible during that period. So, what should the government do to control these unpleasant activities that mar its image? It is certainly doable. The government, civil society, minority socio-cultural organisations and their leaders, as well as media outlets, must be taken on board. Minority sensitivities are crucial and must be understood by the authorities. Also, close monitoring of social media should be maintained to strictly curb rumours, as in this killing inside the shrine, an old video was circulated. If the concerned agencies are alert, this would never happen. Coincidentally, Kushtia is renowned for being the place of the 18th-century spiritual legend Lalon Fakir, who still inspires communal amity and peace. Such incidents are a slur on his contribution. The overall approach to instilling confidence and a sense of security among minorities must be reassuring, as any inadvertent lapse may undo all the good work that the new Prime Minister has undertaken. Views expressed are personal

Boiling Point

The ongoing unrelenting nationwide heatwave signals an urgent need to build climate-resilient systems as weather disruptions are likely to rise

Recently, it’s been so hot in Bangalore that I cannot even recognise the same city anymore. Five years ago, when I shifted here, I had switched on the air conditioner only once in the entire year; that too only for a few hours. Blue-blood Bangaloreans reminisce about sleeping without fans; an air conditioner was never a necessity. This year’s sweltering temperatures are being triggered by a “heat dome” that’s literally trapping hot air over the Indo-Gangetic plains and eastern India, causing air to heat excessively before it descends. This meteorological high-pressure system is rare and cruel. Weak western disturbances, blocked sea breezes, and the “Super El Niño” that tends to weaken the Indian monsoon while leading to longer dry spells, are all contributing to this current hot pot.

Several Indian cities have seen mercury soaring between 40°C - 47°C. Akola at 46.9°C, Banda at 46°C, Nagpur 45°C, Ahmedabad 44°C — the list is uncomfortably long as a nationwide heatwave engulfs us. The gates of hell are open, the heat is on, and May is only just getting started. And to add to the anguish, we are told to brace for more impending spells of heatwave, as per the Indian Meteorological Department (IMD). Some passing showers may bring temporary succour, but back into the heat capsule we will ultimately go. Our power bills will increase, our resources will be more strained and exploited, water shortage will occur — and thus the cycle continues, but only getting worse every year. Between 2000 and 2020, over 10,000 people died due to heatwaves in India, according to the IMD. Elderly, children, migrant workers, and unorganised sector labour are the most vulnerable and exposed sections to climate-led disruptions. This year’s heatwave-linked deaths have already begun.

The future that we had been discussing — of exceptionally high temperatures, erratic rainfall, and unpredictable weather patterns — is here, and is now our lived reality. For those who have been following the climate change conversation, what’s happening today in India and globally, was inevitable. Therefore, now more than ever we need to build sustainably, push development alongside nature, and most urgently push the pedal on creating climate-resilient systems.



This year’s heatwave is driven by a “heat dome” trapping hot air over Indo-Gangetic plains, causing extreme heating before descent

Some work has started but much remains. The Indian government has identified 310 out of 651 agricultural districts as vulnerable to climate change and are working towards promoting climate-resistant farming practices. The government is promoting climate-proof technologies through Krishi Vigyan Kendras (KVKs) in 448 model Climate Resilient Villages in 151 vulnerable districts. Artificial Intelligence (AI) and Machine Learning are being actively deployed to support and educate farmers while also helping with surveillance systems to detect pest infestations early, for instance. The UN agency, UNICEF (United Nations Children’s Fund), is inviting interested parties to help develop climate-resilient WASH (Water, Sanitation and Hygiene) systems in schools and Anganwadi centres in Jharkhand. We are talking of building climate-resilient roads in the Himalayan region! Such decisions, for example, need deeper considerations and reviews by climate experts before getting the government nod.

We must stop decimating forests and green cover in the hollow name of progress. At the administrative and approval levels, this can stop only if climate becomes an election topic. In the recently concluded state elections, there were some promises of tackling floods and climate issues from political parties in Assam and some mention in West Bengal with regard to the protection of farm land from river erosion, banning the fill-

ing up of wetlands, and conservation of mangrove forests. In spite of this, except in Tamil Nadu, where climate action occupied a decisive space in party manifestos, the other states have barely scratched the surface. And the only way this can change in future elections is if we, the citizens of India, demand better air, water, greenery, and climate-proofed systems. At the community level, it breaks my heart to see the pigheadedness of people every day. So myopic are their views and selfish and ignorant their perspectives, that they don’t even realise the damage they continue to do. If they stay on this path, they will leave behind an ecologically fractured world for their numerous progeny to suffer in.

As India formulates its National Adaptation Plan (NAP), we must ensure that the focus remains on a long-term strategy that includes adaptation, inclusivity, and protection of vulnerable populations. Reforestation, conservation of wetlands, and a complete ban on the destruction of green cover should be non-negotiable. Development of green infrastructure, engineered solutions such as cool roofs, vertical walls, biofilters, green buffers, and passive ventilation must become an integral part of urban planning. States, as well as the Centre, need to spend generously and act diligently to implement plans, guarantee outcomes, and enhance accountability. Without this, we are definitely doomed in this hellfire.

Views expressed are personal



WHO SAID
WHAT



Rahul Gandhi
@RahulGandhi

I had said it - the heat of inflation would come after the elections. Today, commercial gas cylinder is ₹993 more expensive. The biggest increase in a single day. This is the election bill. From February till now: ₹1,380 increase - a whopping 81% jump in just 3 months. Tea stall, dhaba, hotel, bakery, sweet shop - the burden on everyone’s kitchen has increased. And this will affect your plate too. First strike on gas, next strike on petrol-diesel.



Arvind Kejriwal
@ArvindKejriwal

Read this news on the front page of the Times of India. It says that sewer water is coming out of the taps in Janakpuri and no one is listening. This situation is not just in Janakpuri but in many areas of Delhi. The BJP’s four-engine government has made life hell for the people of Delhi. And nowhere is there any hearing. In the Delhi elections, the Prime Minister had made big promises. And after winning the election, he went off to campaign in other states. He has left the people of Delhi in a terrible state.



HEZBOLLAH DRONE WOUNDS 2 ISRAELI SOLDIERS

Israel strikes southern Lebanon, 4 people killed

TYRE: Israel carried out several airstrikes on southern Lebanon on Friday, killing at least four people, while the militant Hezbollah group said it fired rockets and drones, including one that crashed in northern Israel and wounded two soldiers.

Israel's military and Hezbollah kept up their attacks despite a ceasefire in place since April 17. The state-run National News Agency reported that the four people were killed in strikes on three southern villages.

Israel's military on Friday afternoon urged residents of the village of Habboush near the southern city of Nabatiyeh to evacuate, warning that those close to Hezbollah's facilities would be putting their lives in danger if they stay.

Friday's exchanges came



UN forces operate in southern Lebanon, as seen from northern Israel AP/PTI

after paramedics recovered the bodies of five people, including a man and his three sons, from under rubble in the village of Kfar Rumman, also near Nabatiyeh, a day after they were killed.

National News Agency

reported that the five were killed in an airstrike late Thursday on Kfar Rumman. The agency identified those whose bodies were recovered as Malek Hamza and his sons, Ali, Fadel and Hamza. It said the strike also killed a

Highlights

» Israel's military on Friday afternoon urged residents of the village of Habboush near the southern city of Nabatiyeh to evacuate

» The Israeli military confirmed that Hezbollah launched an explosive drone that fell in northern Israel near the border with Lebanon

Lebanese soldier. The Lebanese army confirmed that a soldier, Ali Jaber, was killed in the strike.

By Friday afternoon, Hezbollah had issued six statements saying it launched drones and rockets at Israeli military positions. AGENCIES

Iranian Nobel laureate Narges Mohammadi hospitalized

BEIRUT: Iran's imprisoned Nobel Peace Prize laureate Narges Mohammadi has been urgently transferred from prison to a hospital in northwestern Iran after a "catastrophic deterioration" of her health, her foundation said Friday.

The Narges Mohammadi Foundation said the Nobel Prize laureate had two episodes of complete loss of consciousness and a severe cardiac crisis.

Earlier Friday, Mohammadi had fainted twice in prison in Zanjan in northwestern Iran, according to the foundation. She was believed to have suffered a heart attack in late March, according to her lawyers who visited her a few days after the incident. At the time, she appeared pale, underweight and needed a nurse to help her walk. The hospital transfer comes "after 140 days of systematic medical neglect," since her arrest on Dec. 12, the foundation said. AGENCIES

Ukraine says strike hit Tuapse oil terminal, 4th attack in two weeks



REPRESENTATIONAL IMAGE

KYIV: Ukrainian forces struck an oil terminal in the Russian Black Sea city of Tuapse, Ukraine's General Staff said on Friday, marking the fourth attack targeting the region's oil infrastructure in just over two weeks.

Explosions and a fire were recorded on the premises of local oil infrastructure, the statement from the General Staff said. Local officials in Russia said a Ukrainian drone attack sparked the blaze and that no casualties were reported.

The facility had been hit previously on April 16, April 20 and April 28. Regional governor Veniamin Kondratyev said a fire at the city's oil refinery had also been extinguished Thursday, less than 24 hours before the latest strike.

Meanwhile, Russian attacks continued to strike Ukraine.

Russia attacked the western Ukrainian city of Ternopil with over 50 drones on Friday, according to mayor Serhii Nadal. Hits were recorded in industrial facilities and infra-

structure, he said. At least 10 people were wounded, he added, while some neighbourhoods remain without electricity as a result of the mass attack.

Two multi-story residential buildings and port infrastructure in Odesa were damaged after Russian forces launched another overnight drone attack on the southern region, local authorities said.

As a result of the strikes, an apartment in a 16-story building was destroyed and

the roof caught fire. In another high-rise residential building, a fire engulfed the 12th floor, according to Ukraine's Emergency Service.

In a post on Telegram, President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said at least five people were wounded in the region. He said damage from overnight attacks was also recorded in the central city of Kryvyi Rih and the northeastern Kharkiv region, where railway infrastructure was hit. AGENCIES

China plans to expand its space station as NASA phases out ISS

BEIJING: China plans to expand its low-earth orbiting space station, potentially more than doubling in size, as the rival International Space Station (ISS) is set to be phased out by 2031.

Currently, China's Tian-gong and the ISS, a collaborative project involving NASA along with the space agencies of Russia, Europe, Japan and Canada, are in orbit.

NASA plans to retire ISS, the largest human-made structure in space and serve as a continuously occupied laboratory orbiting Earth, which will make the Chinese space station one of its kind orbiting Earth.

China built its space station after it was reportedly excluded

from the International Space Station (ISS) over concerns that its space programme is manned by the People's Liberation Army (PLA).

It is currently the only country to have a space station which became operational in 2022. The station is relatively small compared to the football court-sized ISS, in which several international astronauts have carried out over 3,000 experiments since its operationalisation in 1998.

NASA plans to retire the ISS in early 2031, using a dedicated de-orbit vehicle, being developed by SpaceX, to guide it into a controlled re-entry over the South Pacific, according to reports. AGENCIES

Iran's months long internet shutdown crushes businesses in already battered economy

Iran's 90 million people have been cut off from the internet for most of 2026

TEHRAN: At her studio in Iran's capital, Amen Khademi prepared a fashion shoot for a jacket she designed with Persian-inspired motifs. But even as she applied lipstick to the model, she was distracted, worrying if her business would survive after four months without its main link to customers — the internet.

Iran's 90 million people have been cut off from the internet for most of 2026, one of the world's longest and strictest national shutdowns. That is devastating for an online economy that had long defied government restrictions and international sanctions. From fashion to fitness, to advertising and retailers, many have



REPRESENTATIONAL IMAGE

seen their incomes evaporate.

Khademi hasn't made a sale in months. "The internet outage in the past four months has completely destroyed not only my business, but many online

businesses," she said.

Despite an uneasy truce with the US and Israel, Iran's rulers have refused to reverse the shutdown they have depicted as a wartime necessity.

Despite an uneasy truce with the US and Israel, Iran's rulers have refused to reverse the shutdown they have

But they are facing an outcry as it adds to mass job losses from strikes on key industries and an ongoing US blockade.

Before January, Iranians could access the internet, but authorities blocked a large amount of content. Now, all access to the global web has been shut down. AGENCIES

Indian-origin schoolgirl killed in London during car crash

LONDON: A 49-year-old woman behind the wheel of a car that crashed into a London school killing two eight-year-old girls, including Indian-origin Nuria Sajjad, was on Friday charged with dangerous driving following a reinvestigation of the case.

Claire Freemantle was involved in a collision at the Study Prep School in Wimbledon that led to the death of Indian-origin schoolgirl Nuria and her schoolmate Serena Lau, both eight years old at the time, in July 2023.

An initial investigation into the crash had concluded against any charges in what was believed to be a freak accident.

"The Crown Prosecution Service has decided to prosecute Claire Freemantle, 49, with two offences of causing death by dangerous driving and seven offences of causing serious injury by dangerous driving," said David Malone, Deputy Chief Crown Prosecutor for London North.

An initial probe into the crash had concluded against any charges in what was be a freak accident

The Crown Prosecution Service (CPS) said Freemantle has been informed of the charges by post and will appear before Westminster Magistrates' Court in London on June 16.

AGENCIES

Sport

DC NOW MOVED UP TO SIXTH WITH EIGHT POINTS

Rahul & Nissanka fuel Capitals' seven-wicket win over Rajasthan

JAIPUR: A wonderful exhibition of batting gifts by KL Rahul (75) and Pathum Nissanka (62) overshadowed Riyan Parag's redemptive 90, powering Delhi Capitals to a seven-wicket win over Rajasthan Royals in their IPL match here on Friday.

Parag washed away a lot of criticism with a 50-ball blitz to lead the Royals to a competitive 225 for six. However, Delhi Capitals replied with excellent knocks by Rahul and Nissanka to reach 226 for three.

Parag stayed off the field for a good part of the second innings with a hamstring niggle. Yashasvi Jaiswal did the captain's duty for the Royals.

The Capitals made the best possible start to the chase as Rahul and Nissanka added 102 runs for the opening wicket in just 9.3 overs.

Rahul was a bit slow to begin with, but once he found his groove, the 34-year-old was sublime to watch.

He played shots all around the ground -- a cover drive off Nandre Burger, a pull off Jofra Archer and two imperious back-to-back sixes in the 'V' off Ravi Bishnoi.

Nissanka displayed his prowess in the pull shot, which yielded all his three maximums on the night -- one off Archer and two off Burger.

Rahul brought up his fifty in 27 balls, four balls more than Nissanka, but the latter fell to Jadeja after failing to connect a reverse sweep.

The Bengaluru batter added a further 61 runs with Nitish Rana (33) as the Capitals maintained their momentum.

Both Rana and Rahul, who lofted Archer straight to Donovan Ferreira at long on, fell in the space of six balls and the



Delhi Capitals' Pathum Nissanka (left), celebrates his half century with KL Rahul during an Indian Premier League match in Jaipur on Friday PTI

Highlights

» Delhi Capitals replied with excellent knocks by Rahul and Nissanka to reach 226 for three

» Parag stayed off the field for a good part of the second innings with a hamstring niggle

» Rahul was a bit slow to begin with, but once he found his groove, the 34-year-old was sublime to watch

» The Bengaluru batter added a further 61 runs with Nitish Rana (33) as the Capitals maintained their momentum

Capitals needed 49 runs from that point off 26 balls.

But Ashutosh Sharma and Tristan Stubbs managed that job very well, as DC pulled off their biggest chase in the IPL.

DC now moved up to sixth with eight points while the Royals stayed at fourth with 12 points.

Earlier, Parag vaporised multiple concerns surround-

ing him with a quality 90 as Rajasthan Royals posted a competitive 225 for six.

The Royals skipper was struggling for runs so far this season and if his on-field troubles were not enough, Parag copped a 25 per cent fine handed by BCCI after getting caught on camera vaping inside the dugout.

So, he had a lot to prove,

and the right-hander did it in some style, notching up his first score above fifty in IPL 2026.

In fact, Parag was under serious pressure after the early departure of openers Vaibhav Sooryavanshi, who was yorked by Kyle Jamieson, and Yashasvi Jaiswal, who offered a return catch to Mitchell Starc (3/40), who made his maiden appearance in this IPL.

After all, 12 for two is not exactly the position an out of form batter wants to be in, and the nerves were evident in his loose wafts against Starc.

But the confidence returned to him once he took apart Jamieson in the sixth over through a sequence of 6, 4, 6 -- a pull over mid-wicket and a slice over slips.

Once self-belief returned, it

50

Parag washed away a lot of criticism with a 50-ball blitz to lead the Royals to a competitive 225 for six

reflected in Parag's batting too, those fast hands and audacity resurfaced.

Those elements were on ample display in a tennis-like forehand six over covers off left-arm pacer T Natarajan.

Parag brought up his fifty in 32 balls and added 102 runs for the third wicket with a composed Dhruv Jurel (42).

The dismissal of Jurel barely deterred Parag as he, in the company of middle-order batters like Ravindra Jadeja (20), marched on.

There was a brief period of lull after Jurel's dismissal but Parag broke the lean phase with a hat-trick of boundaries off Jamieson.

Parag and Jadeja milked 53 runs for the fourth wicket before the latter succumbed to Starc.

The Australian quick also snapped Parag's stay, his attempt to loft him over covers ended in the hands of Axar Patel.

RR still needed the cushion of a few more runs and Donovan Ferreira (47, 14 balls) gave them that with a little Tsunami. AGENCIES

India lead Chinese Taipei 1-0 in Thomas Cup quarters

HORSENS: Lakshya Sen produced a stirring comeback, saving two match points to outwit world No. 6 Chou Tien Chen in a gruelling opening singles, giving India a 1-0 lead over Chinese Taipei in the quarter-finals of the Thomas Cup Finals here on Friday.

Lakshya, who trailed for large parts of the contest, showed remarkable resilience to script an 18-21, 22-20, 21-17 victory in a marathon clash lasting one hour and 28 minutes.

With the head-to-head locked at 4-4 prior to this contest, the two engaged in another absorbing duel marked by long rallies, precise strokeplay and intense momentum swings.

Chou displayed his experience in the opening game, recovering from 10-15 down and overturning a late deficit to take the lead. Lakshya, how-



ever, responded under pressure in the second game. Trailing 13-17, the Indian reeled off four straight points to draw level. Chou earned two match points, but Lakshya held his nerve, saving both before closing out the game to force a decider.

The 36-year-old Chou appeared to fade physically

in the third game as Lakshya seized control with an 11-7 lead at the interval and maintained his composure to seal the contest.

India will look to extend the advantage when the doubles pair of Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty face Chiu Hsiang Chieh and Wang Chi-Lin next. AGENCIES

Akash Deep, Harshit unlikely to be fit for Afghanistan series and UK Tour

NEW DELHI: India's premier fast bowlers Akash Deep and Harshit Rana are unlikely to be fit for the upcoming home series against Afghanistan and the white ball tour of United Kingdom as they are still some time away from getting fully match-fit, sources in BCCI said on Friday.

Akash Deep is currently rehabilitating from a back injury while Rana had undergone knee surgery after a ligament tear just days before the start of the T20 World Cup in India.

The duo, contracted with the Kolkata Knight Riders, has already missed playing in the ongoing Indian Premier League. "Akash and Harshit's rehabilitation is on track but there is still a long way to go before they can be released

The duo, contracted with the Kolkata Knight Riders, has already missed playing in the ongoing Indian Premier League

to play matches. If we are talking about Afghanistan and the UK tour, there is no chance of both of them getting fit before that. They are still doing strengthening routines. After that there will be jogging, strides, sprints and then skills associated with 'Return To Play' (RTP) protocols," a BCCI source tracking the development told PTI on conditions of anonymity.

Akash Deep is seen more as a red ball prospect while Rana is very much in the scheme of things in the ODI and T20I formats.

In 2025, Harshit had emerged as India's most successful ODI bowler having scalped 26 wickets in 14 games. Akash Deep's defining moment was a match-haul of 10 wickets against England in Birmingham during the Anderson-Tendulkar series last year.

Those in the know feel that Akash Deep could in fact take more time than Rana to make a comeback to competitive cricket. A more realistic chance for them would be the Duleep Trophy -- the senior men's domestic season opener which is scheduled sometime in August. AGENCIES

Domestic PV sales jump 27% to nearly 4.5 lakh units in April

PV sales in the domestic market were 3.54 lakh units in April last year

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Carmakers began the new fiscal with an estimated 4.5 lakh units of passenger vehicles (PV) sold in April in the domestic market, up 27 per cent, on back of record sales by firms, including Maruti Suzuki, Hyundai & Kia.

The industry continued to benefit from the tailwinds of GST 2.0 carried forward from H2 FY26, along with repo rate cut & I-T benefit, Maruti Suzuki India Senior Executive Officer, Marketing & Sales, Partho Banerjee said. PV sales in the domestic market were 3.54 lakh units in April last year.

MSI posted a record domestic sales of 1,91,122 units in April against 1,42,053 units in the year-ago month. Its previous highest domestic sales were in December 2025 at 1,82,165 units. The company's small cars, comprising Alto, S-Presso, Celerio and WagonR, grew 74.4 per cent, he said, adding it has dispelled the doubts that people had over the future of small cars. He, however, said any hike in petrol prices could have an impact on demand.

Banerjee said the overall PV industry "is expected to be around 4.45 lakh to 4.5 lakhs in April this year and last year, the industry volume (for the same



'The industry continued to benefit from the tailwinds of GST 2.0 carried forward from the second half of last fiscal, along with repo rate cut and income tax benefit'

month) was 3.54 lakh".

Elaborating on the growth drivers, he said, "The three tailwinds of GST 2.0, the income tax relief and the reduction in the repo rates are still going on".

Banerjee said that for Maruti Suzuki, there is a total of 1.65 lakh pending bookings, with the waiting period for its small cars extending to a month, and the company is gradually ramping up production to meet the rising demand.

Tata Motors Passenger Vehicles Ltd said its sales in the domestic market stood at 59,000 units last month against 45,199 units in the year-ago period, a growth of 30.5 per cent.

Homegrown Mahindra & Mahindra reported domestic passenger vehicle sales of 56,331 units against 52,330 units in April 2025, up 8 per cent, its CEO, Automotive Division, Nalinikanth Gollagunta said.

Benefiting from the policy support, Hyundai Motor India Ltd reported a 17 per cent year-on-year growth in domestic sales to 51,902 units in April 2026. It was the company's highest ever for the month of April since its inception.

"We have opened the new financial year on a strong note, carrying forward the momentum built in recent months into April 2026," the company MD

Highlights

- » MSI posted a record domestic sales of 1,91,122 units in April against 1,42,053 units in the year-ago month
- » Tata Motors Passenger Vehicles reported sales of 59,000 units April 2026 against 45,199 units in April 2025
- » M&M posted sales of 56,331 units in April 2026 against 52,330 units in April 2025

Atul Sood said.

Another carmaker, Toyota Kirloskar Motor, reported domestic sales of 30,159 units compared to 24,833 units in April 2025, up 21 per cent. "Our sales performance in April 2026 reflects steady & sustained progress, driven by a strong focus on customer centricity, product excellence & disciplined execution across markets," TKM Executive Vice President, Sales-Service-Used Car Business, Sabari Manohar said.

JSW MG Motor India reported a 3 per cent year-on-year growth in dispatches to dealers at 6,018 units in April 2026 compared to the same month of the previous year.

Similarly, Renault India said it has clocked an over two-fold increase in domestic wholesales at 5,413 units in April 2026 compared to 2,602 units sold in the year-ago month. Nissan Motor India said its domestic sales stood at 3,203 units.

In the two-wheeler segment, Honda Motorcycle & Scooter India (HMSI) said its domestic sales stood at 4.84 lakh units a year ago, a growth of 14.7 per cent.

Royal Enfield said its domestic sales were 1,04,129 units against 76,002 units in April 2025, up 37 per cent.

FPIs pull out ₹60,847 cr in April

With the latest withdrawal, total outflows by FPIs have surged to Rs 1.92 lakh crore in first four months of 2026

NEW DELHI: Foreign Portfolio Investors (FPIs) continued their relentless sell-off in Indian equities, pulling out Rs 60,847 crore (\$6.5 billion) in April primarily due to escalating geopolitical tensions and global macroeconomic uncertainties that dampened risk appetite.

With the latest withdrawal, total outflows by FPIs have surged to Rs 1.92 lakh crore in the first four months of 2026, significantly exceeding the Rs 1.66 lakh crore outflow recorded in the entire calendar year 2025, according to NSDL data.

FPIs remained net sellers in all months of 2026 except Feb-



ruary. They withdrew Rs 35,962 crore in January, followed by an infusion of Rs 22,615 crore in February, the highest monthly inflow in 17 months.

However, the trend reversed sharply in March, with a record outflow of Rs 1.17 lakh crore, and continued into April, with withdrawals of Rs 60,847 crore, the data showed.

Market participants attributed the sustained selling pressure to a mix of global macroeconomic headwinds and heightened geopolitical risks.

Himanshu Srivastava, Principal Manager Research at Morningstar Investment Research India, said April began with heavy selling as escalating tensions in the Middle East pushed crude oil prices higher, reviving concerns around global inflation.

This, in turn, led to reduced expectations of near-term rate cuts and kept global bond yields elevated, weighing on investor sentiment towards emerging markets, including India. FII

Adani unveils internal overhaul to speed up decisions, strengthen contractor partnerships

NEW DELHI: Gautam Adani on Friday unveiled a sweeping internal transformation plan for the Adani Group, aimed at accelerating decision-making, strengthening contractor partnerships and expanding workforce skilling as the group scales up.

Addressing employees on International Labour Day, Adani said the conglomerate will adopt a "three-layer model" to flatten hierarchies and speed up execution, targeting a reduction in decision timelines from days to hours. He said large organisations often slow down due to multiple layers, and simplifying structures would bring clarity, accountability and agility.

The second pillar, a "part-



Adani Group Chairman Gautam Adani

nership model", seeks to streamline operations by working with a smaller pool of reliable contractors and vendors. With over 100 contractors currently operating at several sites, Adani said consolidation would reduce complexity, improve coordination and ensure faster, more efficient project delivery while enhancing accountability.

The group is in an aggressive expansion phase and expects to add assets worth about Rs 2 lakh crore in a single year

The third focus area is learning and development, with plans to set up an Adani Training Academy to drive continuous upskilling and create defined career progression paths. The initiative aims to help workers move from unskilled to skilled roles and into leadership positions over time.

Adani linked the overhaul to

Narendra Modi's vision of making India a developed nation by 2047, stressing the need for collective effort.

The group is in an aggressive expansion phase and expects to add assets worth about Rs 2 lakh crore in a single year, matching what it built over 35 years.

He highlighted key projects such as Mundra port, Vizhinjam port, the Khavda renewable energy park and Navi Mumbai International Airport, alongside the Dharavi redevelopment project in Mumbai.

The group also plans worker welfare measures, including local hiring, skill development, housing for 50,000 workers and large-scale meal facilities, positioning employees at the centre of its growth strategy. AGENCIES



wider investor base.

Shareholders holding one share as of April 29 will receive four additional shares in the new entities, with the stock trading ex-demerger from April 30.

Brokerage firm Emkay Global Financial Services said the move could trigger valuation re-rating, as pure-play companies often

command higher multiples and enable better capital allocation.

As part of the demerger, Vedanta plans to separately list four entities: Vedanta Aluminium Metal Limited (VAML), Talwandi Sabo Power Ltd (TSPL), Malco Energy Ltd (MEL), and Vedanta Iron and Steel Limited (VISL).

The company also reported strong earnings, with net profit rising 89 per cent to Rs 9,352 crore in the March 2026 quarter, supported by higher volumes and favourable global metal prices, according to Motilal Oswal Financial Services. AGENCIES

NSDL Q4 net profit jumps 8.4% to ₹90.3 cr

NEW DELHI: National Securities Depository Ltd

has reported an 8.4 per cent rise in consolidated net profit to Rs 90.3 crore for the March quarter of FY26.

The company had posted a net profit of Rs 83.3 crore in Q4 FY25. The total income grew 23.6 per cent to Rs 487 crore in Q4 FY26 from Rs 394 crore a year ago, the depository said in a statement on Friday.

The board of directors has recommended a final dividend of Rs 4 per equity share (face value Rs 2) for FY26, subject to shareholder approval. For full FY26, NSDL's net profit rose 11 per cent to Rs 380 crore, and total income rose 8 per cent

to Rs 1,660.2 crore.

Separately, the company said it has launched the Women Demat Plan on April 1, offering a three-year waiver on settlement fees for new women account holders. The initiative aims to boost women's participation in capital markets by offering zero transaction fees, no age limit, and allowing joint accounts where the woman is the primary holder.

On a standalone basis, the company posted a net profit of Rs 79.7 crore in Q4 FY26, up 5.2 per cent year-on-year, while total income stood at Rs 195.4 crore, marking a 1.8 per cent rise over the year-ago period. FII

RBI to deepen financial markets, macro fundamentals strong: Guv

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Reserve Bank will keep on deepening financial markets, broadening participation, and further strengthening institutional frameworks, as India's macroeconomic fundamentals remain strong, Governor Sanjay Malhotra said on Friday.

In a keynote address at the 25th FIMMDA-PDAI Annual Conference at Amsterdam, the RBI governor said the conference could not have been at a more opportune time, when the global financial system is navigating through a period of elevated uncertainty and challenges.

These have implications not just for the real sector but also for the financial markets, he said.

Malhotra said that geo-economic fragmentation caused by tariffs, trade restrictions, and industrial policies are reshaping

not only global supply chains, they are also affecting the free movement of capital and leading to the fragmentation of financial flows.

"Overlaying these challenges is the recent escalation of geopolitical tensions in West Asia. Energy prices have risen sharply amidst damage to energy infrastructure and disruptions in supply chains. It has already affected economic activity.

"If the crisis persists longer, it may also translate into second-order inflationary pressures," he said.

Talking about India's economic resilience amid global turbulence, the RBI governor said the domestic demand continues to be supported by strong consumption and public investment.

The government's emphasis on capital expenditure has helped crowd in private investment and improve productive

capacity.

"Resultantly, we have recorded an average growth of 8.2 per cent during 2021-25. In 2025-26, the economy is estimated to have grown by 7.6 per cent. Growth in 2026-27 is projected at 6.9 per cent," he said.

He further said that corporate balance sheets have improved, supported by stronger earnings, and the fund mobilisation by Indian corporates through public markets has remained strong over the last two financial years.

Malhotra emphasised that Indian financial markets have matured considerably over the past few years, which is an outcome of conscious policy choices over the years.

He also noted that while considerable progress has been made in deepening and strengthening the financial markets, more needs to be done, and highlighted five areas of improvement.

PUBLIC NOTICE			Contd..		
Om Co-operative Group Housing Society Ltd.			S.No.	M.No.	DI. of M.C.
H.No. 1, Savitri Nagar, Near Kali Masjid, Malviya Nagar, New Delhi-110017			1	1	Resolution
The general public is hereby informed that in terms of the High court of Delhi order dated 11.05.2011 in Writ petition no. 7706/2010 the names of 110 members and (5 vacancies), the details of which are given below are being forwarded to the office of the Registrar, Co-operative Societies, Government of NCT of Delhi, Old Court's Building, Parliament Street, New Delhi-110001 by the Managing Committee of Om Co-operative Group Housing Society Limited (Regn. No. 580 (GH), Regd. Office: H.No. 1, Savitri Nagar, Near Kali Masjid, Malviya Nagar, New Delhi-110017 for forwarding their names to Delhi Development Authority (DDA) for execution of lease deed for construction of flats for its members through Co-operative Movement for Housing provisions of DCS Act/Rules & DDA norms/guidelines thereof.			2	2	10.10.2003
S.No. M.No. Name Of The Members			3	3	13.09.2003
1	118	S.K. Marwah	4	4	27.03.2004
2	119	Chandni Bhuchar	5	5	20.11.2003
3	120	Harish Anand	6	6	24.10.2004
4	126	Rahul Bhuchar	7	7	18.02.2005
5	128	Manoj Singh	8	8	22.04.2003
6	129	S. C. Mahajan	9	9	20.02.2003
7	130	Sumit Mahajan	10	10	21.07.2003
8	131	Seema Sethi	11	11	28.06.2004
9	132	Sita Rani	12	12	20.02.2003
10	133	Suresh Anand	13	13	22.04.2003
11	134	Varun Anand	14	14	13.09.2003
12	137	Uma Marwah	15	15	27.05.2005
13	139	Harish Duggal	16	16	20.02.2004
14	140	Naveen Chopra	17	17	20.02.2003
15	141	Sweeta Sethi	18	18	20.02.2003
16	142	Rubi Kanth	19	19	18.11.2004
17	143	Dilip Kanth	20	20	15.01.2005
18	144	P. N. Kanth	21	21	20.02.2003
19	145	Naveen Sabarwal	22	22	20.02.2003
20	146	Vishal Anand	23	23	15.01.2005
21	147	Rajesh Talreja	24	24	20.02.2003
22	148	Nalini Verma	25	25	18.11.2004
23	149	Nishi Saggi	26	26	20.02.2003
24	150	Mridula Chhadha	27	27	22.04.2003
25	151	Monika Chhadha	28	28	13.09.2003
26	152	Sudershan Bhatia	29	29	20.02.2003
27	153	Arvind Behl	30	30	20.02.2003
28	154	Sumita Singh	31	31	28.05.2003
29	157	Vinita Suri	32	32	20.02.2003
30	158	Rajiv Malik	33	33	28.05.2003
31	159	Rajesh Khanna	34	34	27.05.2004
32	162	Mohit Khosla	35	35	05.12.2003
33	163	Rajiv Malik	36	36	20.02.2003
34	164	Sanjeev Bhatia	37	37	21.07.2003
35	166	Balljeet Singh	38	38	10.01.2004
36	167	Pankaj Malik	39	39	28.02.2004
37	170	Prahallad Chhetri	40	40	20.02.2003
38	172	Neha Khanna	41	41	20.11.2003
39	173	Kanta Sharma	42	42	28.05.2003
40	174	Chandan Singh	43	43	27.05.2004
41	177	Kishori Lal Sharma	44	44	20.02.2003
42	178	B. K. Hari	45	45	10.01.2004
43	179	Balraj Chhujia	46	46	20.02.2003
44	180	Vivek Sareen	47	47	20.02.2003
45	181	Vinod Sood	48	48	20.02.2003
46	183	Ankit Bhandari	49	49	20.02.2003
47	184	R. V. Behl	50	50	15.01.2005
48	185	Rashi Goel	51	51	20.02.2003
49	186	Sumati Anand	52	52	16.09.2004
50	187	K. K. Sareen	53	53	20.02.2003
51	188	Subhash Sharma	54	54	20.02.2003
52	189	Vinita Suri	55	55	20.02.2003
53	190	N. Sander	56	56	20.02.2003
54	192	M. M. Kapoor	57	57	20.04.2004
55	193	Ram Dilas Rai	58	58	15.01.2005
56	194	Rohit Pandey	59	59	20.02.2003
57	196	Anil Soni	60	60	20.02.2003
58	197	Deepika Bhandari	61	61	10.10.2003
59	198	Rajiv Khanna	62	62	28.02.2004
60	199	Rishi Bhuchar	63	63	20.02.2003
61	200	R. J. Rani	64	64	20.02.2003
62	201	Ravi Pandey	65	65	20.04.2004
63	202	Renu Kapoor	66	66	15.01.2005
64	203	Ankit Manikanta	67	67	13.09.2003
65	204	Vinod Bhatia	68	68	20.02.2003
66	205	Sudhir Kochar	69	69	20.02.2003
67	207	Sangeeta Kampani	70	70	24.10.2004
68	208	Hardyal Singh	71	71	15.01.2005
69	209	Harbhajan Singh	72	72	18.11.2004
70	210	V. K. Vadia	73	73	03.03.2005
71	211	Damanjeet Singh Bhatia	74	74	24.10.2004
72	212	Kuldeep Singh	75	75	27.05.2004
73	213	Meenakshi Chopra	76	76	15.01.2005
74	214	Puneet Singh	77	77	18.11.2004
75	215	V. K. Vadia	78	78	03.03.2005
76	216	Rajesh Chopra	79	79	10.06.2004
77	217	Suman Handa	80	80	28.05.2004
78	220	Anil Sharma	81	81	25.06.2004
79	224	Shelly Kapoor	82	82	18.11.2004
80	226	Mukesh Kumar Sharma	83	83	20.02.2003
81	227	Raj Kumar	84	84	10.06.2004
82	228	Santosh Pandey	85	85	25.06.2004
83	229	Jagdeep Singh	86	86	16.09.2004
84	230	Ashok Kumar	87	87	16.09.2004
85	231	Meera Sinha	88	88	25.06.2004
86	232	Neeru Sareen	89	89	20.02.2003
87	233	Ajay Sharma	90	90	10.06.2004
88	234	Nitin Wadhwani	91	91	10.06.2004
89	235	Anand Prakash	92	92	28.05.2004
90	236	Vijay	93	93	25.06.2004
91	237	K. I. Sharma	94	94	18.11.2004
92	238	Aditya Arya	95	95	03.03.2005
93	239	Amit Bhatia	96	96	10.06.2004
94	241	Amitabh Bhatia	97	97	28.05.2004
95	242	Balram Gera	98	98	25.06.2004
96	243	Yashish Vats	99	99	20.02.2003
97	244	Ashu Mathur	100	100	10.06.2004
98	245	Siddharth Jain	101	101	28.05.2004
99	246	Vinod Mehra	102	102	25.06.2004
100	247	Amit Dhillon	103	103	18.11.2004
101	248	Amir Arora	104	104	20.02.2003
102	249	Pankaj Sharma	105	105	25.06.2004
103	250	Avishka	106	106	16.09.2004
104	251	Gagan Nayyar	107	107	16.09.2004
105	252	Mohan Chandan Pandey	108	108	25.06.2004
106	253	Arshi Sharma	109	109	20.02.2003
107	254	Om Prakash Bhatia	110	110	27.05.2004
5 Vacancies			111	111	20.02.2003
Initially, in the year 1982-1983, 64 Promoter members have applied for registration of the society in the name and style of "Om CO-operative Group Housing Society Ltd." thereafter, the society has enrolled 51 members before approval of the title, leading to total membership of 115 members by the competent authority (64 (Promoter)+51 (enrolled)). Consequently, the freeze strength fixed by the society was approved and fixed at 115 members. Since the society is confirmed by office in its letter no. F-47/580/ GH/SP/Coop/20 dated 13.01.2003. Currently, the society has a strength of 110 members, having 5 vacancies created due to resignations. The freeze strength, 139 members enrolled against 144 resignations, resulting in the current strength of 110 members. Overall, the society has processed a total of 254 applications for its membership. Out of these, 144 members have been removed from the membership register due to rejections or resignations, in accordance with the provisions of the DCS Act and Rules of the Registrar, Co-operative Societies, Govt. of NCT of Delhi. The details of outgoing members are provided below.			112	112	20.02.2003
			113	113	20.02.2003
			114	114	20.02.2003
			115	115	20.02.2003
			116	116	20.02.2003
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			234	234	20.02.2003
			235	235	20.02.2003
			236	236	20.02.2003
			237	237	20.02.2003
			238	238	20.02.2003
			239	239	20.02.2003
			240	240	20.02.2003
			241	241	20.02.2003
			242	242	20.02.2003
			243		

India maintained stable energy supplies amid crisis: Oil Min Puri

‘The country absorbed the global shock at the fiscal level instead of passing it on to consumers, supported by long-term planning’

OUR CORRESPONDENT

SURAT: Union Petroleum and Natural Gas Minister Hardeep Singh Puri on Friday said India has managed to maintain stable energy supplies and shield consumers from global price shocks despite a severe disruption triggered by the closure of the Strait of Hormuz.

Addressing the Vibrant Gujarat Regional Conference (VGRC) for South Gujarat here, he said despite 60 days into energy supply disruption due to the West Asian crisis, India stands strong, and added that the country absorbed the global shock at the fiscal level instead of passing it on to consumers, supported by long-term planning.

The government has been monitoring the supply of crude oil, LNG, LPG, petrol, diesel and aviation fuel daily for over 60 days since the crisis began, ensuring uninterrupted availability across the country, the minister said.

“When a global supply chain faces disruption of 20 to 30 per cent on important routes and products, no country can be insulated from the shock. Freight costs rise, insurance costs rise, cargos are delayed, and every important country



Union Petroleum and Natural Gas Minister Hardeep Singh Puri

The government has been monitoring the supply of crude oil, LNG, LPG, petrol, diesel and aviation fuel daily for over 60 days since the crisis began, he said

is forced to make hard choices,” Puri said in his address.

Despite a sharp rise in global crude prices, India has not revised retail petrol and diesel prices in the last 60 days, he said.

“Sixty days into the disruption, India is standing strong. Under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, India has not allowed Indian kitchens to run short. We have not revised retail petrol and diesel

Highlights

» ‘When a global supply chain faces disruption of 20 to 30% on important routes and products, no country can be insulated from the shock,’ Puri said

» ‘Freight costs rise, insurance costs rise, cargos are delayed, and every important country is forced to make hard choices,’ the minister said

» Despite a sharp rise in global crude prices, India has not revised retail petrol and diesel prices in the last 60 days’

prices. We have not allowed panic to become policy,” the minister added. In India, there has been zero increase at the retail pump during this crisis period, even as global prices surged significantly, he said.

Several countries witnessed steep increases in fuel prices between February 28 - when closure of the strait started - and April 23, including a rise of over 40 per cent in neighbour-

ing regions, while diesel prices in the United States peaked at a 58 per cent increase, he said.

Puri also noted that fuel prices have gone up significantly across Europe.

“In the UK, diesel prices went up by 26 per cent and petrol prices 11 per cent. In Germany and Western Europe, fuel prices have shot up by 19.8 per cent, while overall EU diesel prices rose by 19.1 per cent and petrol 10.6 per cent,” Puri said.

But India absorbed the global shock at the fiscal level rather than passing it on to consumers, supported by long-term planning and timely interventions, according to him.

“As far as the government and our commitment to consumers is concerned, there has been a zero increase - not only in the last 60 days, but also over the last four years” he said.

He refuted claims that the Modi government did not increase prices due to the assembly elections in some states. “Many of our colleagues say that we have kept prices under control because we have an election. We have had many elections in the last four years. If the time comes, the government will take the necessary decisions, but the PM’s commitment to the 33 crore households

getting piped gas remains paramount,” he said. Preparations made over the previous decade to tackle such energy crises were activated exactly when needed during the disruption, he added.

As part of its strategy, India diversified crude sourcing from 27 countries to 41 and expanded LPG procurement to include the US, Norway and Algeria, reducing dependence on traditional supply routes affected by the crisis, according to him.

Domestic LPG production was ramped up by 60 per cent, scaling from 36,000 metric tonnes to 54,000 metric tonnes per day, while consumption was optimised by shifting industrial users from LPG to piped natural gas, ensuring that household demand remained unaffected. “Overall daily consumption was reduced to 80,000 metric tonnes by strategically shifting industrial users from LPG to LNG (piped gas) and incentivizing natural gas usage” he said.

Puri said a coordinated effort under ‘Operation Urja Suraksha’ brought together oil marketing companies, ministries, state governments and global suppliers. Oil companies absorbed under-recoveries, while excise duty cuts and export levies were used to stabilise domestic markets.

Fuel price hike in near future not ruled out, says govt sources

Global crude oil prices this week climbed to a four-year high of \$126/barrel before cooling down slightly

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: An increase in petrol and diesel prices in the near future is not ruled out, government sources said on Friday, as losses mount from a four-year-old freeze in retail rates despite the sharp rise in global crude oil prices.

International crude oil prices this week climbed to a four-year high of \$126 per barrel before cooling down slightly, but remained above \$110 a barrel as ship transits through the Strait of Hormuz remained restricted and US and Iranian leaders traded barbs amid stalled peace talks.

Government sources said the possibility of a petrol and diesel price hike in the near future is not ruled out.

Earlier in the day, Indian Oil Corporation (IOC), making a statement on behalf of the industry, said petrol and diesel price as also domestic LPG rates are not being increased despite a surge in international energy cost.

State-owned oil firms hiked prices of commercial LPG, industrial diesel, 5-kg LPG and jet fuel sold to international airlines in keeping with the cost.

Analysts had earlier flagged the possibility of price increases of Rs 25-28 per litre after the end of polling for assembly elections in West Bengal on April 29.



Analysts had earlier flagged the possibility of price increases of Rs 25-28/litre after the end of polling for assembly elections in West Bengal

International oil prices spiked after the US and Israel attacked Iran on February 28, and Tehran’s sweeping retaliation that effectively shut the Strait of Hormuz — one of the world’s most critical energy arteries, linking the Persian Gulf to global markets and handling roughly a fifth of global oil trade along with significant volumes of liquefied natural gas.

Last week, a senior oil

ministry official told a news briefing that state-owned fuel retailers were incurring losses of about Rs 20 per litre on petrol and roughly Rs 100 per litre on diesel as pump prices remained frozen for nearly four years despite a surge in global oil prices.

Yet there is no plan to increase prices, she had said.

Crude, which was \$70 per barrel last year, averaged over \$114 this month.

Retail petrol and diesel prices have remained frozen since early April 2022 — a period during which oil prices rose in some months and fell in other times. When prices fell, state-owned oil firms made handsome profits, which they used to set off losses when rates rose.

Petrol is currently priced at Rs 94.77 a litre in Delhi, and diesel comes for Rs 87.67.

India & UK discuss ways to boost bilateral trade



NEW DELHI: India and the UK on Friday discussed ways to boost two-way commerce and investments and leverage opportunities under the comprehensive economic and trade agreement signed in July last year.

It was discussed during a virtual meeting between Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal and UK Secretary of State for Business and Trade Peter Kyle.

“We explored ways to further enhance our trade and investment ties while fully leveraging the opportunities under the India-UK Comprehensive Economic and Trade Agreement (CETA),” Goyal said in a social media post.

India and the UK, on July 24, 2025, signed the Comprehensive Economic and Trade Agreement (CETA), under which 99 per cent of Indian exports will enter the British market at zero duty, while tariffs on British products, such as cars and whisky, will be reduced in India.

CETA aims to double the \$56 billion trade between the two economies by 2030. PFI

Windfall tax on diesel exports cut to ₹23/litre, ATF exports to ₹33/litre

The windfall tax was levied to increase domestic availability of fuel amid the US-Israel and Iran war

NEW DELHI: The government has cut the windfall gains tax on the export of diesel to Rs 23 per litre and aviation turbine fuel (ATF) to Rs 33/litre, effective Friday.

The finance ministry, in a statement, said there will be no change in existing excise duty rates on petrol and diesel for domestic consumption.

The special additional excise duty on export of diesel was reduced to Rs 23 per litre from Rs 55.5 per litre, and aviation turbine fuel to Rs 33 per litre from Rs 42 per litre.

The road and infrastructure cess on the export of diesel will be nil for the next fortnight, beginning May 1.



The rate of duty on export of petrol will remain nil, said the finance ministry statement issued late on Thursday.

The government had, on March 26, imposed an export duty at Rs 21.50 a litre on diesel, and on ATF at Rs 29.5 a litre. In a review on April 11, the duties were hiked to Rs 55.5/litre and Rs 42/litre, respectively.

The windfall tax was levied to increase domestic availability

of the fuel amid the US-Israel and Iran war.

The levies were also aimed at not allowing exporters to take undue advantage due to price differences, as globally crude oil prices had risen since the beginning of the war.

On February 28, the US and Israel launched military strikes against Iran, triggering sweeping retaliation from Tehran.

Crude oil prices have surged to a four-year high of \$126 per barrel, from about \$73 per barrel before the war. The windfall tax was to ensure domestic availability of petroleum products by disincentivising exports in the backdrop of the West Asia crises, the ministry said. PFI

‘Sugar exports to be 7.5-8L tonnes in 2025-26 season’

NEW DELHI: India is likely to export only 7.5 to 8 lakh tonnes of sugar in the current 2025-26 marketing season (Oct-September) due to unfavourable global price parity, according to a senior government official.

For 2025-26, the Food Ministry initially allowed 1.5 million tonnes in exports, then opened an additional 500,000-tonnes pool, of which only 87,587 tonnes were approved.

“The full season physical shipments would likely land around 7.5-8 lakh tonnes. There is no parity in global prices for exports to be undertaken at present,” the official said.

India has already exported 5 lakh tonnes as on March 3, and

mills are unlikely to utilise the full-season export quota even though outbound sales were more active earlier in the season, the official added.

Domestic sugar consumption patterns have shifted in recent years, with demand growth stagnating as offtake volumes remain flat.

The trend has reduced overall consumption, leaving tighter-than-expected surplus availability for exports despite a modest recovery in production.

Domestic sugar production has reached 27.5 million tonnes so far this season, with total output pegged at 28.2 million tonnes — slightly above the 26.1 million tonnes recorded in 2024-25. PFI

City Union Bank names Vijay Anand as MD, outlines steady growth plan

CHENNAI: City Union Bank on Wednesday announced a planned leadership transition, with MD & CEO N Kamakodi completing 15 years in executive leadership on April 30, 2026, the maximum tenure permitted under regulations.

Vijay Anand will take over as MD & CEO from May 1, bringing nearly 30 years of banking experience across ICICI Bank, Barclays & RBL Bank, and two years within bank’s leadership.

Under Kamakodi, the bank recorded steady growth between 2011 and 2026, with deposits rising from Rs 12,914 crore to Rs 78,308 crore and advances from Rs 9,255 crore to Rs 65,875 crore. Total business expanded to Rs 1.44 lakh



crore, while net profit grew to Rs 1,327 crore and net worth to Rs 10,459 crore. The branch network increased to around 1,000 despite disruptions such as demonetisation, GST rollout and the pandemic.

The incoming MD emphasised continuity over disruption,

India has again been placed on Priority Watch List in 2026 Special 301 Report released on April 30 by the Office of the USTR

administrative review used by the US as a pressure tool. It does not impose immediate penalties but can lead to negotiations, investigations, and sometimes



trade action if issues escalate.

India was also on the Priority Watch List in 2025 and 2024, showing this is an ongoing status, not a one-time action, the GTRI said, adding that India has remained on the USTR’s Priority Watch List since the 1990s, reflecting long-standing differences with the US over intellectual property policy, especially in pharmaceuticals.

“Overall, while the US cites weak IP protection, India’s position is that it is fully WTO-compliant and that the real difference lies in its refusal to adopt stricter, TRIPS-plus (trade-related aspects of intellectual property rights) standards,” GTRI Founder Ajay Srivastava said.

He added that India supplies nearly 20 per cent of the world’s generic medicines, and generics typically reduce drug prices by

80-90 per cent.

“Provisions like Section 3(d) and compulsory licensing are therefore essential, and evidence shows India has balanced innovation with access. India should continue to defend these principles to protect affordable healthcare and policy sovereignty,” Srivastava said.

He stated that the US pressure on India’s pharma IP regime dates back to the 1990s, driven by strong industry lobbying for stricter protections.

This continues even though India exported \$9.7 billion worth of medicines to America in 2025, mostly low-cost generics that help reduce healthcare costs. “Accepting US demands would weaken India’s generics industry - often called the ‘pharmacy of the world’ - and harm patients globally, including in the US,” he added. PFI

‘India, UAE FTA helps boost trade to cross \$100 billion’

NEW DELHI: The India-UAE FTA, which came into force in May 2022, has helped the bilateral trade to cross \$100 billion, Commerce & Industry Minister Piyush Goyal said on Friday.

The Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA) with the UAE acts as a gateway to Africa, other GCC and Middle Eastern countries, CIS (Commonwealth of Independent States) countries and some European countries.

Bilateral merchandise trade has grown strongly, crossing \$100 billion, with services trade also rising steadily and opening new markets and greater value, he said in

a social media post.

The bilateral trade stood at \$101.25 billion in 2025-26 compared to \$100.03 billion in 2024-25. The trade, he said, has expanded in key sectors like gems and jewellery, engineering goods, electronics, and agriculture.

During 2025-26, India’s exports to the UAE rose about 2 per cent to \$37.36 billion, while imports were up 0.77 per cent to \$63.89 billion, resulting in a trade deficit of \$26.53 billion.

Foreign direct investment from the UAE into India stood at \$2.45 billion during April-December 2025-26. It was \$4.34 billion in 2024-25. PFI

NTPC veterans K M Prashanth and J P Sharma win IPSE Awards

NEW DELHI: K M Prashanth, Former GM (Corporate Communications), NTPC was honoured with the prestigious “Indian Public Sector Enterprise (IPSE) Doyen of the Decade (Public Sector)” Award for his Yeoman Contribution to the cause of NTPC - INDIA’s largest Public Sector Enterprise in Communications and Public Relations in the Power & Renewable Energy domains.

The prestigious Award was given by Anil Razdan , Former Secretary (Power) Govt of India on April 30, 2026 in gracious presence of Sandeep Gupta , Former CMD , GAIL, & A K Singh , Former CMD,

NHPC, at SCOPE Convention Centre, New Delhi.

K M Prashanth is a seasoned professional with extensive expertise in corporate communication, human resources and corporate affairs. With a deep understanding of these areas, he has successfully navigated various roles and responsibilities throughout his more than three decades of career with NTPC.

Prashanth’s experience in leading teams and implementing effective communication strategies made him a valuable asset to NTPC where he contributed significantly to the Organisation’s success.

During the same event, Raz-

dan also presented the IPSE Life Time Achievement Award for Excellence to J P Sharma, former Deputy General Manager (Corporate Communications) at NTPC, for his immense life-long contributions to the field of Corporate Communications.

The IPSE Awards are instituted by PSE Journal in association with the ENERTIA Foundation.

The awards aim to recognize excellence within India’s Public Sector Enterprises across core economy sectors and their vital contribution to the Nation’s GDP, covering both Central and State PSEs as well as individual leadership. MPOST

Panel to oversee banks’ balance sheet constraints: DFS

The government is expected to announce the terms of reference for the panel

CLOSER LOOK

» ‘This committee is expected to review the banking sector with a focus on making it more effective, more inclusive & better aligned with India’s growth needs,’ Nagarajulu said

» Nirmala Sitharaman had proposed setting up a high-level committee on banking to comprehensively review the banking sector in Budget speech on Feb 1, 2026

at the ICPG Growth Conference here.

Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman had proposed setting up a high-level committee on banking to comprehensively review the banking sector. “I propose setting up a High

Level Committee on Banking for Viksit Bharat’ to comprehensively review the sector and align it with India’s next phase of growth, while safeguarding financial stability, inclusion and consumer protection,” she had said in the Budget speech on

February 1, 2026.

On the deepening bond market, Nagaraju said, India needs to develop its corporate bond market so that companies that are not top rated also get access to capital.

“In India, 90-95 per cent of bond issuances are from India are from companies that are AA or above rated. In US, the bulk of the market is A, and BBB rated. The middle tier of bond market doesn’t exist in India,” he said.

Therefore, he said, companies face difficulty in raising funds in long-duration tenors, and long-term capital borrow-

ers must tap the corporate bond market for funds.

“The ability of long-term institutional investors to participate more actively in the corporate bond market will be an important factor in determining how deep and liquid that market can become.

“The supply side needs to develop better secondary market liquidity, lower transaction friction, and greater coherence in how similar instruments are treated across different regulatory frameworks. The bond, the currency, and the derivatives markets need to work together effectively,” Nagaraju said. PFI

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF A PERSON ACCUSED

See Section 82 Cr. P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Pawan@Ganja**, S/o Rohit, R/o E-294, Jhangirpuri, Delhi has Committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in a **FIR No. 325/22 U/s 25/54/59 Arms Act at PS Jhangirpuri, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Pawan@Ganja** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Pawan@Ganja** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Pawan@Ganja** of **FIR No. 325/22 U/s 25/54/59 Arms Act at PS Jhangirpuri, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **02.06.2026**.

By order
Ms. Jyoti Nain
NMFC-07, North District
Rohini Court, Delhi

DP/5747/NW/2026(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Hitesh S/o Chander Pal R/o G. No. 5 Shukar Bazar Road, Bhajanpura, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case registered vide **FIR No. 539/2019 U/S 356/379/411/34 IPC, PS Nand Nagri, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said accused **Hitesh** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Hitesh** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Hitesh** of **FIR No. 539/2019 U/S 356/379/411/34 IPC, PS Nand Nagri, Delhi** is required to appear before this court (or before me) to answer the complaint on or before the day of **05.06.2026**

By Order,
Ms. Deepakshi Rana
Judicial Magistrate First Class- 03
Room No. 19, First Floor, Shahdara District
Karkardooma Courts, Delhi

DP/5583/NE/2026(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 CrPC/84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Mohd. Akram S/o Sh. Mainuddin R/o T-403, Gali No.20, Gautampuri, Seelampur, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case registered vide **FIR No. 140/2019 U/s 10-12 G-Act, PS Bhajan Pura, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said accused **Mohd. Akram** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Mohd. Akram** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Mohd. Akram** of **FIR No. 140/2019 U/s 10-12 G-Act, PS Bhajan Pura, Delhi** is required to appear before this court (or before me) to answer the complaint on or before the day of **01.06.2026**

By Order,
Sh. Pankaj Rai
Judicial Magistrate First Class-01
Room No. 73, 5th Floor, North-East District
Karkardooma Courts, Delhi

DP/5711/NE/2026(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused person Namely **Aizul @ Azizul S/o Sheikh Siddiq R/o Jhuggi No. N - 38/A-304 CD Park Jahangirpuri Delhi**, has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 329/23 U/s 25/54/59 A. Act PS: Jahangirpuri Delhi**, and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Aizul @ Azizul** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Aizul @ Azizul** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Aizul @ Azizul** accused of ted (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 329/23 U/s 25/54/59 A. Act PS: Jahangirpuri Delhi**, is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **05.06.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Jyoti Nain
JMFC-07, Room No.-6
Rohini Court, Delhi

DP/5717/NW/2026
(Court Matter)

NORTHERN RAILWAY

TENDER NOTICE No. 08/2026-2027 Dated: 30/04/2026

Invitation of Tenders through E-Procurement system

Principal Chief Materials Manager, Northern Railway, New Delhi - 110001, for and on behalf of the President of India, invites e-tenders through e-procurement system for supply of the following items :-

S. No.	Tender No.	Brief Description	Qty.	Closing Date
01	77269001A -RGC	10125MM CURVED SWITCH THICK WEB	1600 SET	26-05-26
02	09263032	ENAMEL SYNTHETIC, EXTERIOR, FINISHING, WHITE	48144 LTR	01-06-26
03	09262505	SNUBBER SPRING	2340 NOS	09-06-26
04	02262202	SELF PRIMING MONOBLOCK PUMP	3732 NOS	22-06-26
05	02261935	BATTERY BOX FOR NON-AC COACHES 110 V	565 NOS	13-07-26

Note : 1. Vendors may visit the IREPS website i.e., www.ireps.gov.in for details. 2. No Manual offer will be entertained. 1456/2026

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PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused person Namely **Neeraj @ Annu S/o Ramesh Chand R/o E-57/958 Gali No. 10 H-Block Sunder Nagri Nand Nagri Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 197/2023 U/S 25 A Act PS: Nand Nagri Delhi**, and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Neeraj @ Annu** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Neeraj @ Annu** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Neeraj @ Annu** accused of **FIR No. 197/2023 U/S 25 A Act PS: Nand Nagri Delhi**, is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **05.06.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Deepakshi Rana
JMFC-03, Room No. 19
Karkardooma Court, Delhi

DP/5733/NE/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr. P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused person Namely: **Amit, S/o.: Raju, R/o.: UT Jhuggi No. 182, Mangol Puri, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No.139/2024 U/S 392/411/34 IPC** registered at **P.S. Raj Park, Outer District, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Amit** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that accused **Amit** is absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Amit**, accused of **FIR No.139/2024 U/S 392/411/34 IPC** registered at **P.S. Raj Park, Outer District, Delhi** is required to appear before the court to answer the said complaint on or before **05.06.2026**.

By Order, Ms. Ebbani Aggarwal
Judicial Magistrate First Class-03,
Room No.107, 1st Floor,
Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/5737/OD/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Sahil, S/o Sh. Ashok, R/o H.No. A-1/308, Sultanpuri, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 01/2024, U/s 25/54/59 Arms Act, P.S. Hari Nagar, New Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Sahil** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Sahil** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Sahil** accused of **FIR No. 01/2024, U/s 25/54/59 Arms Act, P.S. Hari Nagar, New Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **05.06.2026**.

By Order - Ms. Moksha Bains
Judicial Magistrate First Class-11, West
Room No. 31, Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi

DP/5693/WD/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Ravi, S/o: Shri Krishan, R/o: H. No. C-35, D-30, Rajdhani Park, Nangloi, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 204/2019 U/s 279/338 IPC/3/181 MV Act, P.S.: Mundka, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Ravi** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Ravi** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Ravi** accused of offence in case **FIR No. 204/2019 U/s 279/338 IPC/3/181 MV Act, P.S.: Mundka, Delhi** and is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **01.06.2026**.

By Order
Sh. Gaurav Singal
Judicial Magistrate First Class-06 (West)
Room No. 355, Tis Hazari Court, Delhi

DP/5655/OD/2026
(Court Matter)



NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

Tender Notice No.- 1320262027

Date- 27.04.2026

E-Tendering Tender Notice

Divisional Railway Manager (Engineering)/North Central Railway/ Prayagraj, for and on behalf of the President of India, invites E-TENDERS on prescribed form for the following work upto 13.30 hrs. on 22.05.2026. The details of the Tender are as under:

S.N.1. Tender No: 43 **Name of work:** Combined Tender For: (A) Improvement of Railway Colony Road at ALJN under ADEN/ALJN. (B) Provision of Additional Water Booths in the section of Sr. DEN/IV/PRYJ.

Approx Cost of work: ₹ 8443275.30

Earnest Money: ₹ 168900.00

Completion Period: 8 months

Date of opening of tender: 22.05.2026

Eligibility Criteria for similar work: Any Civil Engineering work

S.N.2. Tender No: 44 **Name of work:** Annual P.Way Zone for Period ending 30.06.2027 under ADEN/TDL

Approx Cost of work: ₹ 10250000.00

Earnest Money: ₹ 205000.00

Completion Period: 30.06.2027

Date of opening of tender: 22.05.2026

Eligibility Criteria for similar work: Any P.Way work

Note- 1. Tender Forms shall be issued free of cost to all tenderers. 2. The complete information along with tender document of above E-TENDER is available on Website www.ireps.gov.in up to 15.30 hrs. on the due date of tender opening i.e. 22.05.2026. 3. Bids other than in the form of E-Bid shall not be accepted against above tenders. For this purpose, vendors are required to get themselves registered with IREPS website along with Digital Signature Certificate issued by CCA under IT Act-2000. 4. The tenderers shall submit a copy of certificate as given in tender document in standard format, without which their tender may not be considered and shall be summarily rejected. 5. In case of any difficulty helpdesk available on the website of IREPS may be approached. 6. The tenderer has to submit necessary documents in compliance of clause 10 to 18 (Part-I) of GCC April 2022 mandatorily, otherwise offer will be considered. As Incomplete offer and accordingly shall not be considered. 932/26 FA



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NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

No.: AGC/TRD/T/2026/12

Date : 27.04.2026

E-Tender Notice

Sr. DEE/TRD/Agra for & on behalf of President of India invites "Open Tender" through on-line only (e-Tendering) for the following work:

Tender No.: AGCTRD/T02612

Name of work: Replacement of Contact wire having Brazing joint by jointless contact wire over Agra Division (Ph II)

Approximate Cost : ₹ 4,36,70,160/-

Earnest Money: ₹ 8,73,400/-

Period of completion: 12 months

(1) For full details & submission of the bid please see the Indian Railway website www.ireps.gov.in. (2) Tender can only be submitted through web portal www.ireps.gov.in up to 15:30 Hrs. on date 20/05/2026. 937/26 (MG)



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www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in



NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

T. Notice No. 230-Elect/TRD/PRYJ/E-Tender Notice/2026/633

Date : 28.04.2026

E-Tender Notice

Sr. Divl. Electrical Engineer/TRD/N.C. Rly/Prayagraj, for and on behalf of the President of India, invite the following E-Tender, the details of the tenders are as under:-

Tender No. : 230-TRD-WC-1022-2026

Advertised value : Rs. 82,63,872.78

Description of work : 25KV OHE modification work due to replacement of old FOB by 6.10M new FOB at Sirathu (SRO) station and raising of platform at Sujatpur (SJT) station of Prayagraj Division.

Bid Security : Rs. 1,65,300.00

Completion Period : 12 Months

Bidding system : Single Packet

Tender Closing date & Time : 20.05.2026 & 14:00 Hrs

Tender opening date & Time : 20.05.2026 & 15:00 Hrs

Note : 1. The complete information along with tender document of above E-Tenders shall be available on Website www.ireps.gov.in 21 days prior to the date of opening of the tender. 2. Bids other than in the form of E-Bids shall not be accepted against above tenders. For this purpose, vendors are required to get themselves registered with IREPS website along with Digital Signature Certificate. 3. In case of any difficulty helpdesk available on the website of IREPS may be approached. 946/26 (C)



North central railways



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NORTHERN RAILWAY OPEN E-TENDER NOTICE

The Sr. Divisional Engineer-II, Northern Railway, Delhi Division invites E-Tender for the following work.

NIT-	Name of work: Repair to road surface and improvement of level crossing No. 52, 56, 60, 61, 62, 64, 65, 69, 71, 74, and LC-4C in the section of SSE/W/ MOZ of ADEN/MUT under jurisdiction of Sr. DEN-IIDL.	Earnest Money to be deposited	₹211500.00
10			
Approx cost of work	₹10572953.95		
Date & Time of opening of tender	26.05.2026 15:00 Hrs.		
Website particulars where complete details of tender documents can be seen.	www.ireps.gov.in		

*The tenderer/s must be registered on the Indian Railway E-Procurement system (IREPS) site i.e. www.ireps.gov.in for participating in the e-tender system. *For all terms and conditions please refer tender document. *No manual offers are acceptable. *Cost of tender document and Earnest money will be acceptable through net banking or payment gateway only.

No. 128-W/280/e Tender Notice/NIT-10-26-27-W-II Dated:- 30.04.2026

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PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C./84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person, namely, **Narender, S/o Sh. Subhram Singh, R/o H.No. 212, Main Bus Stand, Village Hamidpur, Alipur, Delhi**, (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 284/2017, U/s 279/338 IPC & 3/181 MV Act**, registered at **P.S.: Alipur, Delhi**, and the warrant has been returned writing upon that the said accused person, **Narender**, cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person, **Narender**, has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said, accused person, **Narender, FIR No. 284/2017, U/s 279/338 IPC & 3/181 MV Act**, registered at **P.S.: Alipur, Delhi**, is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **03.06.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Priyanka Rajpoot, Ld
Chief Judicial Magistrate
Distt. North, Court No. 115, First Floor,
Rohini Court, Delhi

DP/5728/ON/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Surkhasha Sanhita

Whereas a complaint has been made before me that accused Persons Namely **Wasim Khan S/o Aftab Khan R/o C-3/566, Nand Nagri Delhi** have committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence under **FIR No. 99/2015 U/s 30 DBCP Act**. has been registered at **P.S.Nand Nagri, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest there upon issued that the Said, **Wasim Khan** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said, **Wasim Khan** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused, **Wasim Khan** of **FIR. No. 99/2015 U/s 30 DBCP Act**. has been. registered at **PS. Nand Nagri, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **03.06.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Deepakshi Rana.
Ld. MM, Room No.19
Karkardooma Court, Delhi

DP/5580/NE/2026
(court notice)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 Cr. P.C./84 BNSS)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused **Lakshay Nayyar S/o Ashok Nayyar R/o WZ 384, Gali No. 2, Shree Nagar, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 705/2015 U/s 324/34 IPC, PS Hari Nagar, Delhi** and it has been returned to warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said accused **Lakshay Nayyar** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Lakshay Nayyar** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that **Lakshay Nayyar** in **FIR No. 705/2015 U/s 324/34 IPC, PS Hari Nagar, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **02.06.2026**.

By order
Ms Moksha Bains
Judicial Magistrate First Class-11
Room No. 31
Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi

DP/5700/WD/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr. P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person(s) **Nikhil Kumar, S/o: Sh. Deepak Kumar, R/o: H.No. 825 Gali No. 21/3, Shiv Kunj Sant Nagar Burari, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 233/2020, Dt. 22.04.2020, U/s: 380/411/34 IPC, PS: Wazirabad, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **Nikhil Kumar**, cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **Nikhil Kumar**, has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person(s) **Nikhil Kumar**, of **FIR No. 233/2020, Dt. 22.04.2020, U/s: 380/411/34 IPC, PS: Wazirabad, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **09.06.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Sayesha Chadha
Judicial Magistrate First Class-08
Room No. 272
Tis Hazari Court, Delhi

DP/5670/N/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person(s) **Darshan, S/o: Suresh R/o: Gali No. 03 Bada School Mandoli Chungi Harsh Vihar, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 454/2023, U/S: 356/379/34 IPC, PS: Nand Nagri, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **Darshan** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **Darshan** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person(s) **Darshan** of **FIR No. 454/2023, U/S: 356/379/34 IPC, PS: Nand Nagri, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **10.06.2026**.

By Order
Deepakshi Rana
Judicial Magistrate First Class-03
Room No.19, 1st Floor Shahdara Distt.,
Karkardooma Court, Delhi

DP/5590/NE/2026
(Court Matter)

COURT NOTICE
(U/o 5 Rule 20 CPC)
IN THE COURT OF
Sageer
Additional Civil Judge
(Senior Division), Rohtak
Nidhi daughter of late Rajesh
jindal and wife of Rakesh Kumar
Mittal
Vs.
General Public
succession certificate
CNR No. HRR02-000391-2026
Next Date 30-07-2026
PUBLICATION ISSUED TO:
General Public
:-
India
In above titled case, the defendant (s)/ respondent(s) could not be served. It is ordered that defendant(s)/ respondent(s) should appear in person or through counsel on 30-07-2026 at 10:00 am.
For details logon to <https://highcourtchd.gov.in/7trs> = district notice & district = Rohtak
Sd/- Sh. Mohommad Sageer
Additional Civil Judge (Senior Division),
Rohtak
dated 30.04.2026

Next Date 17-08-2026
M/555 MOTORS
CNR No. HGR02-001633-2019
PUBLICATION ISSUED TO:
M/555 MOTORS
SHOP NO 9, SHRI RAM MARKET,
MISHORN WALA BAGH, SEC-12A, GGM
ALSO AT H NO 1417/3 STREET NO 7
RAJIV NAGAR NEAR SHIV MANDIR
GURUGRAM
In above titled case, the defendant (s)/ respondent(s) could not be served. It is ordered that defendant(s)/ respondent(s) should appear in person or through counsel on 17.08.2026 at 10:00 am.
For details logon to <https://highcourtchd.gov.in/7trs> = district notice & district = Gurugram
Sd/- Dr. Mohd. Imtiyaz Khan
Civil Judge (Junior Division)
Gurugram
Dated 20.04-2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Bunnu @ Anil, S/o: Gyan Chand, R/o: K-275, Nardan Basti, Lal Kuan, Pul Prahladpur, New Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 810/2024, U/s 304(2)/317(2)/238(C)/3(5), Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhila, 2023, P.S.: Okhla Industrial Area, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Bunnu @ Anil** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Bunnu @ Anil** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Bunnu @ Anil** accused of offence in case **FIR No. 810/2024, U/s 304(2)/317(2)/238(C)/3(5), Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhila, 2023, P.S.: Okhla Industrial Area, Delhi** and is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **02.06.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Akansha Gautam
Judicial Magistrate First Class-02
Room No. 513, Saket Court, Delhi

DP/5703/SE/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(SEE SECTION 82(2) (ii) Cr.P.C./84 BNSS)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person(s) **Aniket S/o Karamveer R/o G. No. 2, Near Agarwal Sweet, Jhhadoda Village, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 35954/2023, U/s 411/34 IPC Act, PS Welcome, Delhi** and it has been returned to a Warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **Aniket** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **Aniket** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person(s) **Aniket** of Case **FIR No. 35954/2023, U/s 411/34 IPC Act, PS Welcome, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before dated **02.06.2026**.

By Order
Deepakshi Rana
Ld. Metropolitan Magistrate-03
Room No. 19, North-East Distt,
Karkardooma Courts, Delhi

DP/5380/NE/2026
(Court Matter)



NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

Tender Notice No.: 1420262027

Date: 28.04.2026

E-TENDER NOTICE

Divisional Railway Manager (Engineering)/North Central Railway/Prayagraj, for and on behalf of the President of India, invites the following E-Tenders on prescribed form for the following works up to 13:30 hrs. on 22.05.2026. The details of the tenders are as under:-

S.No.: 1	Tender No.: 45
Name of Work: Annual Civil Repairs and Maintenance and small new work in zone work from SKB (Incl.) to TDL (Excl.) and Horticulture work for the P.E. 30.06.2027 underADEN/FZD.	
Approx Cost of work (Rs.): ₹ 17935247.43	Bid Security (Rs.): ₹ 358700.00
Completion Period: 30.06.2027	Date of Opening of Tender: 22.05.2026
Similar work for Eligibility Criteria: Any Civil Engineering Work	
S.No.: 2	Tender No.: 46
Name of Work: Annual Civil Repairs and Maintenance and small new work in zone work from SKB (Incl.) to FBD (Excl.) for the P.E. 30.06.2027 underADEN/FZD.	
Approx Cost of work (Rs.): ₹ 9857457.28	Bid Security (Rs.): ₹ 197200.00
Completion Period: 30.06.2027	Date of Opening of Tender: 22.05.2026
Similar work for Eligibility Criteria: Any Civil Engineering Work	
S.No.: 3	Tender No.: 47
Name of Work: Annual Civil Repairs and Maintenance and small new work in zone work from BNT (Incl.) to JGR (excl.) and Horticulture work for the P.E. 30.06.2027 underADEN/ETW.	
Approx Cost of work (Rs.): ₹ 15387365.98	Bid Security (Rs.): ₹ 307800.00
Completion Period: 30.06.2027	Date of Opening of Tender: 22.05.2026
Similar work for Eligibility Criteria: Any Civil Engineering Work	
S.No.: 4	Tender No.: 48
Name of Work: Annual Civil Repairs and Maintenance and small new work in zone work from RRH (Excl.) to BNT (Excl.) for the P.E. 30.06.2027 underADEN/ETW.	
Approx Cost of work (Rs.): ₹ 14750395.01	Bid Security (Rs.): ₹ 295000.00
Completion Period: 30.06.2027	Date of Opening of Tender: 22.05.2026
Similar work for Eligibility Criteria: Any Civil Engineering Work	
S.No.: 5	Tender No.: 49
Name of Work: P.Way zone work for the P.E. 30.06.2027 in the section of ADEN/FZD.	
Approx Cost of work (Rs.): ₹ 20300000.00	Bid Security (Rs.): ₹ 406000.00
Completion Period: 30.06.2027	Date of Opening of Tender: 22.05.2026
Similar work for Eligibility Criteria: Any P.Way Work	
S.No.: 6	Tender No.: 50
Name of Work: P.Way zone work for the P.E 30.06.2027 in the section of ADEN/ETW.	



She talked about her husband Aditya Dhar 'unaffected' by *Dhurandhar*'s Rs 3,000 crore success

NOTHING CHANGED US: YAMI GAUTAM

Filmmaker Aditya Dhar's two-part film 'Dhurandhar' has been on a record-breaking spree ever since its release. Together, the two films have earned over Rs 3,000 crore at the box office, besides acclaim from the ticket-paying audience. The latest release, 'Dhurandhar 2', starring Ranveer Singh, has already become the third highest-grossing Indian film ever. With praises from fans and the entire film industry already flowing in, the



director's wife, actor Yami Gautam, has also given it a thumbs up.

In a recent interview, she opened up about the film's success and how it motivated Bollywood to work on strong scripts. During a conversation with 'Grazia', she used 'Dhurandhar' as an example and spoke about the film industry's growth graph.

She used 'Dhurandhar' as an example and spoke about the film industry's growth graph

"All these definitions have changed now and I think 'Dhurandhar' is the best example. Each character has left an impression because the characters are written in that sense. I've understood this also stems from a sense of industry culture, that this is the female actor, this is the male actor, this is the hero - it's possible to dis-

mantle that completely and chase brilliant characters and writing," Yami said.

"Which is why I always go back to 2019 to 'Urr' and 'Bala', because when you are celebrating a moment. It is never about just that; it's about the journey that led you to it. This is why I said it was always a director's medium - it was always script and all those basic things that make a film, a film. The basics are back, so that's a massive shift. It's not just about a film doing well and new box office records. I don't think Dhurandhar's success tells us only that. We were struggling to get people into theatres and we were figuring and toying around with things. But people thronging theatres tell you, 'We are ready,'" she added.

When asked if her and Aditya's perspectives have changed after Dhurandhar's massive success and shattering box office numbers, Yami replied, "Nothing has changed us as people. That also comes from Aditya and the kind of person he is - very unaffected and extremely humble. I've seen him through different phases. There are highs and lows and vulnerable phases, but it's not like during that phase we expressed our frustration or let it out."

"Both of us are extremely thankful to God, for us spirituality is very important; we believe in the Almighty," she concluded. AGENCIES

CICD marks 50 years with launch of 'Sonal Mansingh Award'

OUR CORRESPONDENT

The Centre for Indian Classical Dances (CICD), founded by Padma Vibhushan Dr Sonal Mansingh, inaugurated its Golden Jubilee Year celebrations, marking 50 years of sustained contribution to India's cultural landscape.

The evening marked several significant milestones, including the unveiling of the Golden Jubilee logo and the screening of a special audio-visual presentation chronicling CICD's distinguished journey since its inception on April 30, 1977. A major highlight of the occasion was the institution of the 'Sonal Mansingh Award', a prestigious honour to be conferred annually on two dancers in recognition of their outstanding contribution to Indian classical dance. The evening also saw the announcement of a special mentorship programme under the aegis of Dr Sonal Mansingh, aimed at nurturing two young dancers and guiding them in their artistic journey. The programme commenced with the 'Shri Kamakhya Kalapeeth Stotra', followed by classical dance presentations by senior disciples and artists of CICD, including 'Ganesh & Natesh Kavutvam' and 'Kevat Prasang' and concluded with the 'Swasti Vachan shloka'.

Speaking on the occasion, Dr Sonal Mansingh said, "CICD was



conceived as a space for training in dance, allied arts and for a journey of life through art. It is inclusive and in harmony with changing times yet deeply rooted in Bharatiya ethos. Over these 50 years, CICD has sought to nurture artists who are sensitive individuals, connected with traditions yet aware of the world they inhabit. Time-honoured philosophical concepts, lore and legends from the Veda, Upanishads and Puranas inspire Indian classical dances. Our responsibility now is to ensure that this knowledge is meaningfully transmitted to future generations. The Golden Jubilee is a celebration of what has been achieved as well as a firm commitment to continue on the golden path."

The event in New Delhi was attended by eminent personalities

from the worlds of art, culture and public life, including Delhi Legislative Assembly's Speaker Vijender Gupta as Chief Guest and Dr Sudhanshu Trivedi, Member of Parliament, Rajya Sabha, as Guest of Honour. Several distinguished guests were present, including members of Parliament Sangeeta Yadav and Ranjeet Ranjan; Dr Sandhya Purecha, Chairman, Sangeet Natak Akademi; Dr Sachchidanand Joshi, Member Secretary, Indira Gandhi National Centre for the Arts; Prof Dinesh Singh, former V-C, Delhi University; Guru Shovana Narayan and others.

The Golden Jubilee year will unfold as a series of curated engagements across the country, including performances, dialogues and initiatives that seek to deepen conversations around Indian classical dance, its pedagogy and its continuing relevance in a rapidly changing cultural landscape. Established in 1977 in New Delhi, CICD, also known as Shri Kamakhya Kalapeeth, emerged at a time when the national capital had limited institutions offering a holistic engagement with Indian classical dance. Conceived not merely as a training centre but as a space of 'sadhana'. The institution brought together dance with its allied disciplines of yoga, Sanskrit and music, creating an integrated framework for artistic and personal development.



Shoojit shares about alternate romantic ending for 'PIKU'

MUMBAI: Filmmaker Shoojit Sircar said the 'romantic' sensibilities of Irrfan Khan, his late friend and the lead actor of 'Piku', almost altered the final scene of the 2015 film. At a special screening of 'A Story That Refused to Die', the documentary on Irrfan's film 'Paan Singh Tomar', the director fondly recalled the romantic side of the late actor.

"Not many people know that Irrfan was a romantic person. While we were shooting the last sequence of 'Piku' where Deepika and Irrfan are playing badminton and it was cut. Irrfan came to me and said, 'Should I not go inside the house?' I was like, 'Why do you want to go inside?' He was like, 'I should rather go inside the house, since it's a romantic film and the house help comes, I'll go.' I was like, 'We can shoot it as an option' and he insisted that I keep this in the final edit. We shot that, but I didn't keep it during the final edit," Shoojit said. AGENCIES

Ashutosh Gowariker appointed festival director for 57th IFFI

Gowariker succeeds Shekhar Kapur, who headed the 55th and 56th editions of the festival

NEW DELHI: Filmmaker Ashutosh Gowariker, known for films such as 'Lagaan', 'Swades' and 'Jodhaa Akbar', has been appointed festival director for the 57th edition of the International Film Festival of India (IFFI).

Gowariker succeeds filmmaker Shekhar Kapur, who headed the 55th and 56th editions of the festival, held annually in Goa. In a statement, the Information and Broadcasting Ministry said Gowariker is an acclaimed filmmaker with a distinguished contribution to Indian cinema.

"His association with IFFI spans several decades, reflecting his deep engagement with the evolution of cinematic arts and international film culture," the ministry said.

Gowariker said the appointment gave him immense pride



and joy. "I feel privileged to have witnessed the evolution of this festival. From attending it in 1984 to continuing my association over the years, right up to 2024, when I served as the Jury President for International cinema," he said.

The 62-year-old director said carrying forward the festi-

Gowariker said the appointment gave him immense pride and joy

val's legacy was both an honour and a responsibility. "To carry forward the legacy that has been created, nurtured and expanded over the decades since 1952 by innumerable festival teams, is a great honour, accompanied by a renewed sense of responsibility. I look forward to working closely with the Ministry of Information and Broadcasting and the government of Goa," he added.

The International Film Festival of India, established in 1952, is one of Asia's premier film festivals and serves as a significant platform for showcasing excellence in global cinema and promoting cultural exchange. PFI

Stanley Tucci & Emily Blunt get stars on the Hollywood Walk of Fame

LOS ANGELES: Stanley Tucci and Emily Blunt received the prestigious stars on the Hollywood Walk of Fame at the double star ceremony.

The stars are provided to individuals who have achieved excellence in motion pictures, television, radio, music or live theatre. Several celebrities have been honoured at the Hollywood Walk of Fame over the years, including Harrison Ford, Marilyn Monroe, Michael Jackson, Tom Hanks, Dwayne Johnson and others.

The actors, who recently worked together in "The Devil Wears Prada 2", were felicitated on Thursday in Los Angeles. Blunt, who has been previously awarded with SAG, Golden Globe and BAFTA awards, received the 2,841st star and Tucci, known for appearing in over 100 films, had the 2,842nd star. The stars are located at 6930 Hollywood Boulevard on the South side of the street.

The ceremony was attended by Blunt's husband, filmmaker John Krasinski, alongside Meryl Streep, Johnson, Robert Downey Jr and others. "The Hollywood Chamber of Commerce is proud to welcome Emily Blunt and Stanley Tucci to the Hollywood Walk of Fame. A double star ceremony like this is rare and it



feels especially meaningful to honour two artists whose work and friendship have resonated so deeply with audiences around the world," Walk of Fame Producer, Ana Martinez said. "Emily and Stanley have each built amazing careers on their own, but there is a special bond they have as stars of both 'Devil Wears Prada' films. Celebrating them together on the Walk of Fame will be a moment that reflects both individual achievements and the genuine connection they share." PFI

Evangeline Lilly slams Disney for mass Marvel layoffs

She also accused them of turning their back on the people who built 'Marvel' from the ground

Marvel Studios' and 'Marvel Entertainment' had to do several rounds of layoffs in April this year. The step was taken as part of the cost-cutting measures at 'The Walt Disney Company', affecting over 1,000 employees. The budget cuts led to reductions in the Visual Development department, finance, legal and comics divisions, with many veteran people losing their jobs.

In a recent video message on social media, MCU star Evangeline Lilly, who played the role of Wasp in 'Ant-Man', slammed 'Disney' for the lay-offs. She also accused them of turning their back on the people who built 'Marvel' from the ground.

Taking to her 'Instagram' handle, Lilly addressed the mass layoffs at 'Marvel' and said, "I reached out to my good friend Andy Park, who was the genius behind creating the original Wasp super-suit and concept drawings and I said, 'Is this true? Is this really what's happening?' He said, 'Yeah, it's true.'"

She also expressed her stress over the possibility of AI replacing artists. The actor continued, "I can't quite believe that 'Disney' has let go of the artists who brought the 'Marvel Universe' to life through



their genius and that the people who invented these characters and who designed them are being replaced by AI. AI that will take their designs and take what they created and use it to create iterations of that. I am so sorry, Andy. I am so sorry to every one of the artists who were let go."

The caption of her post read, "'Disney', SHAME ON YOU for turning your back on the people who built the power you are now using to throw them away," she wrote, praising Marvel's artists 'who designed and brought to life the glory days of Marvel... I was there. I know what you did. I know how passionately you worked

around the clock to make magic happen. You are the magicians, no matter what the Wizards of our new Oz make it look like going forward. I will never forget'.

"Where are the laws that REMOVE all human art from the AI bank?? Why do they get to steal our brilliance and use it to make executives rich while the artists responsible for feeding their robots go hungry?? Disgusting. California lawmakers... Where are you?!?!" the 'Ant-Man' star urged California legislators to intervene. AGENCIES



The MCU star also expressed her stress over the possibility of AI replacing artists